

ABOUT THE AUTHORS' HUB

The **Authors' Hub** is a vibrant global community where writers connect across borders to exchange ideas, critique literary works, and refine their craft. It was conceived as a meeting point for emerging and established voices to engage in meaningful dialogue about literature, theatre, film, and the wider creative industries. In an era defined by rapid change, the Hub provides a stable intellectual space for writers to learn from one another and to situate their work within both local and global conversations.

To build a sustainable writing career, one needs more than talent alone. One requires conversation, exposure, and constructive engagement. Talent may open the door, but it is sustained dialogue that sharpens technique, expands imagination, and builds resilience. The Authors' Hub recognises this reality and is structured to ensure that every member has access to the kind of critical feedback and mentorship that transforms potential into practice.

At the heart of the Hub is the principle of direct dialogue. Members are brought into conversation with writers, editors, scholars, and practitioners from different cultural and professional contexts. These exchanges broaden perspectives and challenge assumptions, enabling writers to see their work through new lenses. Whether you are drafting your first short story or preparing a manuscript for publication, the Hub offers a space where your ideas can be tested, refined, and strengthened.

The platform also attends to the professional dimensions of writing. We understand that the art of writing cannot be divorced from the business of writing. Through panel discussions, workshops, and networking sessions, members gain insight into publishing, intellectual property, branding, literary entrepreneurship, and the digital marketplace. This dual focus ensures that writers are equipped not only to create compelling work, but also to navigate the structures through which that work reaches its audience.

Ultimately, the Authors' Hub is an invitation: an invitation to belong, to contribute, and to grow. It is a community committed to excellence, collaboration, and the belief that literature thrives when writers support one another. We welcome you to join us, to share your voice, to learn from others, and to become part of a global movement that is shaping the future of writing.

REPORT on the Author's Hub Monthly Panel Discussion

By

Celina Chinwemmeri Ikechukwu

INTRODUCTION

Authors' Hub's 10th Monthly Panel Discussion.

Theme: *AI and the Future of Creative Writing*

28th February 2026 | 4:30 PM – 6:00 PM | via Google Meet.

The session convened distinguished writers, scholars, and literary practitioners to critically examine the evolving relationship between artificial intelligence and contemporary literary production.

The discussion was moderated by Nasiba Babale, a poet, literary curator, and author of *The Rain Is Like You and Pickled Moments*, and Creative Director of Poetic Wednesdays Initiative. She guided the conversation with thought-provoking questions on originality, authorship, ethics, and the shifting standards of literary excellence in the digital age.

The panel featured esteemed speakers, including:

1. **Amadou S. Jallow** (Fantasista) is a Gambian writer dedicated to amplifying marginalised voices through African storytelling. His work explores love, war, belonging, and healing. He is the author of *Sunshine & Rain* and *Break*, with a forthcoming novel, *Don't Touch Her*.
2. **Dike Chukwumerije** is a socially conscious poet whose work blends art and civic engagement to challenge polarising narratives and promote social renewal. He is Creative Director of Simply Poetry Ltd, Executive Director of Simply Poetry Foundation, and Founder of the Dike Chukwumerije Center.
3. **Kabura Zakama** is a poet and development practitioner integrating poetry, publishing, and cultural policy. Founder of Kairos Tablets & Scrolls Ltd, his current work examines artificial intelligence, authorship, language preservation, and the future of African literary production.
4. **Richard Ali** is a lawyer, writer, and cultural entrepreneur working across literature and publishing. He authored *City of Memories* and *The Anguish and Vigilance of Things*. A founding member of Jalada Africa, he co-founded Parresia Publishers and currently serves as Executive Director of Engaging Borders SRD.
5. **Ezekiel Fajenyo** is an award-winning writer and literary scholar known for prolific cross-genre scholarship and cultural criticism. Based in Lagos, he has authored and edited numerous works documenting Nigerian literature and public life and has been honoured by Abuja ANA for his contributions.

There was a significant turnout of participants comprising established authors, emerging writers, scholars, and members of the literary community, who actively engaged in the discussion through questions and commentary. They included Prof. Akachi Ezeigbo, Prof. Idris Amali, Prof. Razinat Mohammed, Dr. Usman Oladikpo Akanbi, Dr. Lizi Ben-Iheanacho, Dr. Awele Ilusanmi, Dr. Chika Ose-Agbo, Malam Denja Abdullahi, and other distinguished writers.

THE DISCUSSION

Amadou S Jallow

Jallow described African creatives as custodians of memory and inheritance in an age of algorithms. “To be a creative in this modern world of chatbots is proving to be more and more difficult, but what it means to us is to be custodians of our creativity, of our memory.”

He distinguished between AI generation and human creation, noting that while AI produces from existing databases, African writing emerges from lived experience, emotion, and cultural memory. “AI generates, but not from scratch... Yet we remember, we feel. AI does not.”

Warning against reducing African literature to mere “content,” he stressed that African storytelling is rooted in oral tradition, rhythm, proverbs, and communal inheritance. “Our art and creativity cannot be shrunk to fit content because it is inheritance.”

Using a vivid metaphor, he likened AI to a DJ: “AI is like a DJ at a party, it remixes data to satisfy its audience. But you cannot remix inheritance and creativity.”

For Jallow, originality is not merely about authorship but about lived experience; who feels the pain, carries the history, and understands the silence between the lines.

He encouraged writers to engage technology responsibly, referencing tools like Microsoft Copilot, but cautioned: “Use AI as your pilot partner, not as the pilot driving the plane.”

Young writers, he advised, may use AI for research, brainstorming, clarity, and translation, but never as a ghostwriter. The real danger, he argued, is not artificial intelligence but complacency. “The real danger is not AI; it is us.”

While AI offers speed, he maintained that depth and originality remain uniquely human. The future of African creative writing, he concluded, lies not in extinction but transformation; reserved for those who embrace technology without surrendering authenticity.

Dike Chukwumerije

Dike acknowledged that change is already visible. “The short answer is yes, there are changes.” He noted that although AI-generated work is becoming more common, it is still, for now, relatively easy to detect. According to him, one can often sense when a piece lacks personal exertion or bears the polished but detached texture of machine production. To illustrate, he shared a striking anecdote. A friend once prompted AI to write a poem “in the style and voice” of Dike Chukwumerije. The result, though impressive, felt uncanny. “It was crazy... but it was different from how I write.”

While he acknowledged AI's growing sophistication, he admitted concern about the future: "I fear the day when this technology becomes so good that it is hard to tell the difference."

Building on earlier remarks by Jallow, Dike supported the idea of using AI as a research assistant rather than a creative substitute. He highlighted its usefulness in translation, historical reconstruction, and immersive detail-building. For instance, a writer crafting a scene set in 1920s Ibadan could use AI to gather contextual descriptions, architecture, vehicles, atmosphere details that enrich storytelling.

"As writers, we need details," he emphasized, noting that AI can help a writer penetrate time and space, stretching imaginative reach. However, he firmly rejected outsourcing the "seedlings" of one's creativity to a machine. "Asking AI to create on your behalf the seedlings of your creative ability... is not right." Drawing parallels with earlier eras of poetry slams, he recalled how plagiarism was once detected through simple google searches. With AI, he observed, the challenge is different. It is not straightforward plagiarism, making it more complex to identify, except where linguistic construction betrays artificial assembly.

For Dike, the concern is not the existence of the tool, but its potential to blur authorship and authenticity. While AI can enhance craft and research, it must never replace the human imagination at the core of creative work.

Dr. Kabura Zakama

Zakama began by situating AI within a historical and technological progression. He noted that early AI systems were rudimentary, performing basic compilations and mechanical aggregations of information. However, AI technologies are evolving rapidly, with tech companies continuously refining chatbot systems to make them more sophisticated and context-aware. "AI can create opportunities for creative writers beyond simple editing support."

He explained that AI itself is not inherently the problem; rather, the concern lies in how creatives choose to engage with it. Over-dependence on AI poses a greater threat to creative integrity than the technology itself. He said true creative writing must retain an element of craft; discipline, skill, intentionality, and artistic labour. Where writers surrender that craft to automated systems, the depth and originality of literature are compromised.

He observed that currently people fall into three broad categories regarding AI: Those who distrust it completely and refuse to engage with it. Those who fully embrace and rely on it. And those who neither admire nor reject it, using it strategically and selectively.

He also highlighted the serious ethical and legal considerations surrounding AI. When AI enhances or generates a work, questions of authorship, copyright, and ownership become complex and contested. "Ultimately, avoiding AI is unrealistic. The more sustainable approach is collaboration. Leverage its capacity to strengthen your work, but preserve your craftsmanship; do not allow it to supplant your individual voice or creative identity."

For Zakama, the future of creative writing is not defined by the mere presence of AI, but by the responsibility of writers to maintain artistic standards. AI may continue to improve, but the sustainability of creative writing depends on human commitment to craft rather than

convenience.

Richard Ali

Asked about the ethical and legal implications of AI in creative work, Ali built on previous speakers, particularly Dike Chukwumerije's example: "Let's begin with Dike's example of somebody prompting an AI to create a poem in his voice. And who knows how the AI did it? But it is very possible that the AI did it so well that the original Dike wondered whether the other, unoriginal Dike was the original Dike." He said AI does this by scavenging previous works written by the author.

He emphasized that AI has become central to creativity, yet raised fundamental concerns regarding authorship and intellectual property: "If an AI engine can generate a Dike or a Kabura or a Richard Ali, for just a 7,000 Naira subscription every month, why should anyone buy the original works? People might simply ask AI to create in the style of the author. This threatens the very possibility of original authorship."

Ali, however, acknowledged that AI can be a useful tool: "I have no problem when AI is used to structure ideas or assist in the creative process. But when AI mimics the creative output itself, it risks replacing genuine authorship with imitation over time."

He drew a historical analogy: "I personally think the book itself may be considered the earliest form of artificial intelligence. When you read a book by someone you've never met; whether Cicero or a contemporary scholar, you absorb their ideas. Books have always functioned as repositories of intelligence extending beyond the individual mind."

Ali outlined three major ethical and legal challenges posed by AI: Erosion of authorship – AI imitation may undermine original creative identity. Intellectual property abuse – AI systems are trained on publicly available works, often without consent, infringing on creators' rights. Cultural extraction – African ideas and motifs are absorbed into AI systems without fair recognition, reflecting a post-colonial digital extraction.

He also presented a devil's advocate perspective, reflecting on Africa's technological engagement: "While the people developing AI advanced globally, Africa largely did not put our money where it mattered. We became consumers rather than producers. The dominant language today is mathematics; the language of coding, while debates on English, Luo, or other languages are outdated."

Despite this, Ali stressed that Africa must defend its intellectual property and regulate AI: "We cannot just accept further colonization of our creative works. Our IP rights must be protected. Legal frameworks like Nigeria's NDPR, modeled on the EU's GDPR, provide guidance, and regional bodies such as ECOWAS should ensure fair access and protections for our data and creative outputs."

In conclusion, Ali positioned AI as a powerful but ethically complex tool: it can support creativity and research, but unchecked reliance, lack of consent, and cultural extraction threaten the integrity of authorship and African cultural representation.

Ezekiel Fajenyo

Fajenyo reflected on the resilience and dedication that defines modern writers, as well as lessons from literary history: “The moment you try to manipulate things or play on their intelligence, they understand the direction of your action and are bound to push you aside and look for something fresh, something they can identify with.”

He emphasized that contemporary writers are motivated by sacrifice, endurance, and the quest for excellence, striving to create works that can be claimed authoritatively and respected globally.

Fajenyo drew on examples from literary history to illustrate the timeless demands of creative work: “Some of us at Authors’ Hub remind ourselves of the past; Shakespeare, Victor Hugo, Agatha Christie, Gabriel García Márquez. We know their stories: how some were eccentric, how they faced tremendous challenges to pursue their craft. Marquez, for example, almost bankrupted his family while developing *One Hundred Years of Solitude*, which eventually won him international acclaim.”

He framed creativity as a pursuit that transcends immediate recognition: “Every creative writer should ask: what happens to my work when I’m gone? It’s a fundamental question. You don’t want only a few people to read your work and then forget it. You want to create something everlasting. If Shakespeare is still studied, if these works are still relevant hundreds of years later, it shows the endurance and impact a committed writer can achieve.”

Fajenyo further argued that AI cannot replace the human experience at the heart of creativity. He said while AI offers efficiency, precision, research support, and economic opportunities, it also promotes laziness, undermines originality, and fosters impersonation or academic dishonesty.

According to him, AI cannot replace the writer because creative writing relies on imagination, emotional truth, and lived experience. Ten writers addressing the same subject will produce ten uniquely personal works. AI cannot replicate this.

On the consequences of over-reliance, he said dependence on AI risks a loss of trust, originality, and self-confidence. Public perception may shift to asking, “Did you write this, or did AI do it?”, creating a “crisis of belief.”

Fajenyo concluded that while technology, including AI, provides new tools, the core of creativity remains human dedication, experience, and vision. He argued that no tool can replace the commitment and personal investment required to produce lasting literary works.

Q&ASEGMENT

Ezekiel Lkoh (attendee):

“Some writers now use AI to generate their work and present it as their own. For beginner writers, however, AI can serve as a supportive tool to help shape their stories. Should young writers rely on AI assistance while developing their craft?”

Richard Ali:

Before relying on AI, writers must first master the fundamentals of writing. Not everyone is naturally a writer, but everyone has the potential to tell a story. This potential is realized through deep reading, studying great works, and analyzing narrative techniques.

For instance, when reading canonical texts like *The Gods Are Not to Blame*, *Animal Farm*, or works by Michael Ondaatje, writers should study how tension is built, how endings resonate, and how characters are structured. This analytical approach reveals the principles of craft. Writers must also observe their world actively and identify stories that truly need to be told. Meaningful literature requires solitude, reflection, and disciplined effort. The emotional and intellectual labour that AI cannot replicate.

AI can assist with research or contextual details, such as reconstructing Ibadan in 1982 for historical accuracy. But while AI can add flesh to the story, the skeleton; the core idea, structure, and emotional insight must come from the writer.”

Ali stressed that AI-generated stories often feel hollow because they lack human experience and emotional depth. While AI can refine ideas, the writer’s originality and intellectual fingerprint must remain central.

Abubakar Bababayo (attendee):

The concern is not merely writers using AI as an aid, but those who wish to appear creative without developing their own intellectual capacity. Some aspiring writers rely entirely on AI from the start, outsourcing the creative process. Such individuals cannot truly be considered creatives, as they do not engage their imagination or intellect. This raises a critical question: "How can we preserve originality and authenticity in creative writing while still using AI tools to enhance our work?"

Aanuoluwa Ngozi (attendee):

One of the biggest challenges for young writers is the absence of a robust literary ecosystem that nurtures originality and mentorship. Using Nigeria as an example, Ngozi emphasized that structured support systems are essential for emerging writers to develop authentic voices. Without mentorship and encouragement, it becomes difficult to produce work that resonates widely while remaining original.

Ngozi also highlighted the potential cultural bias of AI, noting that systems may reflect Western assumptions or defaults, which can distort creative representation. This emphasizes the importance of cultural ownership and diverse voices in AI-assisted writing.

Discussants' Final Remarks

Amadou S. Jallow:

AI itself is not the problem. The issue lies with creators who neglect discipline and rely entirely on AI-generated output.

Both extremes are risky: Complete rejection of AI may lead to obsolescence. Allowing AI to replace human creativity erodes originality and voice. Writers must find a thoughtful middle ground, integrating AI responsibly as a supportive tool rather than a substitute.

Kabura Zakama:

“The future belongs to creators who master their craft, maintain originality and integrity, and integrate AI thoughtfully as a supportive tool rather than a substitute for creativity.”

Ezekiel Fajenyo:

Key advice for writers: Be self-confident. Awaken and utilize your innate gifts. Prioritize originality. Avoid over-relying on AI; assert independent creativity. Write consistently. As Epictetus said, "If you wish to be a writer, write!"; creation demands labour; what Thomas Edison called “99 percent perspiration.” AI can act as a limited assistant, helping with research or organizing ideas, but it cannot replace human insight, emotional depth, or creative labour.

Richard Ali:

Ali thanked the organizers and participants and underscored the session’s key lesson:

“While AI can assist, the essential work of creation belongs to the human author. Writers must strike a balance; preserving originality and emotional truth while responsibly leveraging AI technologies.”

Summary – Key Takeaways

- AI as a supportive tool: Enhances efficiency, research, and detail but cannot replicate human imagination.
- Preserve originality and authorship: Over-reliance risks eroding genuine creative identity.
- Intellectual property and consent: AI trained on existing works raises questions of ownership and fair benefit.
- Cultural representation: African voices must be protected to prevent systemic bias and cultural extraction.
- Mentorship and literary ecosystems: Structured guidance is crucial for young writers to cultivate authentic voices.
- Craft and discipline: Deep reading, analysis, and reflective practice remain the foundation of meaningful literature.
- Balanced integration of AI: Responsible use ensures writers maintain relevance, originality, and creative control.

Celina Chinwemmeri Ikechukwu, the Rapporteur, is an award-winning writer. She is the winner of the maiden edition of the Awele's Heart Short Story Peace Prize.

Report On The Authors' Hub Monthly Panel Discussion

By

Celina Chinwemmeri Ikechukwu

INTRODUCTION

The Authors' Hub 12th Monthly Panel Discussion, themed **The Art and Business of Writing: What Young Writers Should Know**, was held on 28th March 2026, from 4:30 PM to 6:00 PM via Google Meet.

The session which had a large turnout of attendees, brought together accomplished writers, scholars, and literary practitioners to explore the creative and professional dimensions of writing, with particular focus on guiding emerging writers in navigating both craft and career sustainability.

The discussion was moderated by **Mrs. Mercy Enwongulu**, a distinguished literary scholar, poet, and author of *The Maiden and Soldier Boy*. A Senior Lecturer at Isa Mustapha Agwai I Polytechnic, Lafia, and Vice Chair of the Association of Nigerian Authors (ANA), Nasarawa State Chapter, she brought both academic depth and practical literary experience to the conversation, steering the session with clarity and insight.

The panel featured an array of distinguished speakers:

1. **Professor Amanze Akpuda** – A renowned Nigerian poet, literary scholar, and film critic whose work has significantly contributed to the study of African literature and cinema. A Fellow of the Association of Nigerian Authors and member of the Film Educators Guild of Nigeria, he teaches at Abia State University, Uturu. His works include *Not Yet the Guillotined Mind* and several critical studies on African literary forms.
2. **Mr. Surender Panthri** – An Indian writer based in New Delhi, has a diverse career spanning creative and professional writing, including greeting cards, journalism, television drama, and documentary writing. With over two decades of experience in public relations and learning technologies, he has, in recent years, focused primarily on poetry, reflecting on the resilience and discipline required in the creative journey.
3. **Senator Shehu Sani** – A writer, playwright, poet, and human rights activist whose literary voice emerged during periods of incarceration under military regimes. His works, including *Prison Anthology*, *Killing Fields*, and *Phantom Crescent*, interrogate themes of injustice, power, and resistance, while his advocacy continues to support literary and civic consciousness.
4. **Mr. Eriata Oribhabor** – A prominent Nigerian poet, editor, and publisher, widely recognized for his contributions to contemporary Nigerian poetry. Founder of the Poets in Nigeria (PIN) Initiative, he has played a pivotal role in mentoring young writers through competitions, workshops, and literary development programmes.

- 5. Dr. Lola Akande** – An award-winning academic and fiction writer whose works have received both national and international recognition. Her novel *What It Takes* won the ANA Prize for Prose Fiction (2017), while *Suitors Are Scarce in Lagos* earned the ANA Prize for Short Stories (2022). She currently teaches African Literature at the University of Lagos.

The session was hosted by **Sumaila Isah Umaisha**, founder and coordinator of Authors' Hub.

Moderator's Opening Remarks

Mrs. Mercy Enwongulu opened the session by emphasizing that writing goes beyond creativity, requiring insight, emotional depth, and the ability to connect meaningfully with readers while building a sustainable literary career. She noted that the discussion would draw from the diverse expertise of the panelists to guide young writers on developing their craft, navigating the publishing landscape, and positioning themselves professionally.

She concluded by expressing confidence that participants would leave the session informed, inspired, and better equipped to write with purpose and direction, while also appreciating the efforts of the coordinator, Mal. Sumaila Isah Umaisha.

PROFESSOR AMANZE AKPUDA

Responding to the opening question, Professor Akpuda emphasized the importance of balancing reading with active writing in the development of a writer. He acknowledged that drawing from tradition and the works of established authors is essential, but cautioned against overindulgence in reading at the expense of practice: "It is possible to keep reading endlessly and never find the time to actually write." According to him, while some writers need to study older works to refine their craft, balance remains crucial.

Drawing from his experience teaching creative writing, he explained that he often encourages students to engage practically with writing. For instance, when students suggest topics, he sometimes connects them to familiar texts such as *Things Fall Apart*, asking them to reflect on their understanding or imitate stylistic elements like the opening of a novel or drama.

He also highlighted the spontaneous writing exercises in his classroom, noting that some students come in without ever having written before. In such cases, he asks them to produce a poem on the spot, which is then reviewed. Stronger pieces are selected and collectively critiqued to help others identify what makes them effective. Through this process, students begin to recognize qualities they may not have attempted in their own works.

He concluded by reiterating that while reading is valuable, it must not overshadow practice: "You must also make time to write."

MR. SURENDER PANTHRI

Responding to the question on versatility and the business of writing, Mr. Panthri reflected on his journey across multiple forms of writing, emphasizing openness, adaptability, and self-discovery. He noted that at the beginning of his career, he did not have a rigid plan or a clearly

defined path. With a background in literature and mass media, his primary goal was simply to engage in creative work wherever opportunities presented themselves. This lack of strict direction, combined with the fact that financial gain was not his initial motivation, allowed him the flexibility to explore different writing fields, from greeting cards and journalism to scripts and training content.

From this experience, he implied that versatility is not always a calculated strategy, but often a result of staying open to growth and experience, especially in the early stages of a writing career.

He also offered a profound reflection on the nature of writing and success, noting that: "Writing is not necessarily meritocracy. You can be great and yet not sell, and you may sell and not be great." He said writing is driven by something deeper than market success, emphasizing that writers create because of an inner necessity: "One writes because there is no other way to share what is fermenting inside."

Overall, his response highlighted the unpredictable nature of the writing profession and the importance of passion, flexibility, and persistence in navigating both the creative and business aspects of writing.

DR. SHOLAADEKUNLE (Representing Mr. Eriata Oribhabor)

Speaking on behalf of the President of Poets in Nigeria, Dr. Shola Adekunle addressed the question on the habits and disciplines required for young writers to transition from casual writing to building a serious literary career.

She emphasized that creativity remains foundational, describing poetry as an art that depends on the effective use of language and meaningful communication. According to her, young writers must approach writing with intentionality and discipline, taking deliberate steps to master their craft. She outlined several key practices necessary for growth, including active engagement with mentors, participation in writing workshops, and involvement in literary communities. She stressed the importance of wide and consistent reading across genres, as well as seeking constructive feedback to refine one's work.

Dr. Adekunle highlighted that writing is deeply rooted in passion, but cautioned that expression must be thoughtful and purposeful: "Expression should not be careless; it should be reflective, intentional, and inspired." She further encouraged writers to expose themselves to both traditional and contemporary forms of poetry, noting that while modern styles such as spoken word and free verse are evolving, they must be grounded in a solid understanding of established conventions: "Before attempting to break the rules, you must first understand them." In addition, she advised young writers to actively pursue opportunities such as residencies, scholarships, and literary programmes, while surrounding themselves with supportive creative communities.

Addressing the realities of the profession, she noted that although poetry can be deeply fulfilling, it may not immediately provide financial stability. As such, she advised writers to remain pragmatic: "It is important to have a backup source of income."

She concluded by reaffirming that passion and persistence are central to a writer's journey, and

that with consistency, growth and opportunities will inevitably follow.

DR. LOLAAKANDE

Responding to the question on how young writers can develop strong narrative techniques and thematic depth, Dr. Lola Akande approached the discussion from both a creative and critical perspective, beginning with a clarification of key concepts.

She explained that narrative techniques refer to the methods a writer employs in telling a story, describing them as tools used to shape both the structure and impact of a narrative. According to her, writing, particularly the novel, is purposeful and must function as a cohesive whole: “A novel is an organic whole... all parts must come together.” Elaborating on key techniques, she highlighted point of view as central to storytelling. He noted that First Person (“I”) creates intimacy between character and reader. Second Person (“you”) rarely used, is difficult to sustain in long works. Third Person can be omniscient, limited, or objective. She said writers must select the point of view that best suits their story on different levels of intimacy and scope.

She also discussed structure, contrasting linear storytelling with non-linear approaches, where narratives may begin from the middle and later unfold background events.

Using *No Longer at Ease* as an example, she illustrated how a story can begin near its climax before retracing its progression, thereby sustaining reader engagement.

Dr. Akande further emphasized the importance of characterization, describing it as essential to creating believable and dynamic figures, as well as techniques such as stream of consciousness, which attempts to mirror the natural flow of human thought. She also noted that the use of tension and suspense must be handled with care to avoid confusion. Importantly, she drew a clear distinction between narrative techniques and literary elements, stressing that while techniques are optional stylistic choices, elements such as plot, theme, character, and setting are fundamental to every story. On thematic depth, she explained that it refers to the underlying meaning of a narrative, the layer that gives a story significance beyond its surface. According to her, this is achieved by engaging deeply with human experiences, emotions, and realities.

In her concluding advice, she cautioned young writers against over-fixating on technique: “Let the story guide the technique, not the other way around.” She encouraged them instead to focus on authenticity, coherence, and emotional truth, noting that excessive concern with technicalities can weaken the natural flow of storytelling.

Overall, her contribution underscored the need for balance, combining technical awareness with genuine expression to produce meaningful and compelling literature.

Contributions from Participants:

DR. AWELE Ilusanmi, fANA

Dr. Awele focused on the business side of writing, emphasizing that young writers should approach their craft with both creativity and commercial awareness from day one. From the very beginning, while honing craft, learning, editing, networking, and seeking feedback, writers

should already cultivate a business mindset. She highlighted the importance of preparation: “If you suddenly decide to launch a book without preparation, you’ll face a key question: Who are you launching your book to if you haven’t built an audience?” Writing success, she explained, requires balancing craft, growth, and business awareness; “Quality work + strategy = sustainable success.”

She stressed that waiting until the end to consider the business side risks missing crucial opportunities. She encouraged writers: “Put in the work in your craft. The first step is creativity, and another is marketing your creativity. Do not shy away from publishing and marketing your books.” She added: “When young writers do this effectively, they may even find that they no longer have enough time to do everything they want, because of the many opportunities and responsibilities that come with success.”

She concluded that this proactive approach has led to her books being sold out even before printing.

Esther Arikanki asked:

How can experienced writers give back and support upcoming talents?

Mal. Denja Abdullahi:

In response to the question, Mal. Denja said mentorship must be intentional. Emerging writers should actively seek guidance and create opportunities to engage with experienced writers. Structured support, such as paid publications, grants, residencies, and compensated platforms, enables writers to focus, reflect, and produce high-quality work.

Having answered the question, Mal. Denja went on: “I can consider myself a member of the ‘old guard.’ Traditionally, writers did not begin writing with the goal of becoming famous or making money. We started writing because we had something to say. We were deeply concerned with craft and theme.” He emphasized, “Interestingly, it is often those works, written with sincerity and purpose, that later bring the fame and financial reward we never initially pursued.”

He advised young writers not to prioritize money but to focus on: Developing their craft. Having something meaningful to say. Creating work that can impact readers.

He acknowledged the realities of today’s professionalized writing world: “Writers are expected to earn a living from their work, but writing has become increasingly difficult, even for experienced writers, due to daily pressures and challenges. When basic needs are not met, it becomes hard to focus, reflect, and create.”

He also noted that economic realities affect audiences: sometimes readers are not in a position to engage with new work, which adds another layer of challenge for writers today.

Dr. Rasheedat Ajakaye

Dr. Rasheedat shared that her writing journey began without support, facing doubts and silence, but persistence and self-belief were crucial. She emphasized that beginners should believe in

themselves, take action without waiting for validation, and revisit early works, as growth comes through practice, feedback, and learning from others.

Mr. Clem

Mr. Clem, speaking as a young writer, emphasized the value of online publication as a tool for growth rather than immediate commercialization. He said online platforms should be “a way of creating awareness for yourself, building your audience, and receiving constructive criticism.” Through this, writers can identify strengths, improve weak areas, and grow steadily in their craft.

He further advised: “Write out of passion, not just with the intention of making money.” Writing from passion helps young writers:

- Discover their niche
- Understand what inspires them
- Develop a consistent creative flow
- Overcome writer’s block naturally

Dr. Chika Ose-agbo

Dr. Chika emphasized the importance of commitment and consistency in mastering the writing craft. She reinforced the idea that young writers must remain dedicated to learning and refining their skills over time.

She also referenced Dr. Awele’s advice, highlighting that writers should “know what to say and always speak up.” This underscores the dual responsibility of writers to both develop their craft and actively engage with their audience.

Panelists Final Remarks:

Prof. Amanze Akpuda

Prof. Akpuda reflected on his experience teaching creative writing to first-year students as part of the CC-Mas course requirement. He emphasized, “Creative writing is possibly the only course that exposes them to the practical ways of making money as literature students. If they are able to create strong work, whether in poetry, drama, or prose, they can achieve significant financial success.” He disclosed that the current Year One students in the Department of English at Abia State University are exceptional, consistently producing “two poems, or a piece of drama” each session, which they review and discuss immediately. Prof. Akpuda noted, “When students are teachable and receptive, it makes the mentor’s role much easier and more fulfilling. Personally, I truly enjoy teaching them; both in physical classrooms and through online platforms.”

Mr. Surender Panthri

Mr. Panthri emphasized that poetry blends emotion, insight, and language, but young writers

must balance artistic integrity with visibility and financial sustainability. He advised: “Master the craft first; visibility should follow craft.”

Dr. Shola Adekunle

Dr. Adekunle highlighted that writing today is not just an art but also an economic tool. She emphasized that writers must make their work accessible, relatable, and clear, using simple yet powerful language to connect with readers.

Dr. Lola Akande

Dr. Akande highlighted that writing today extends far beyond books. Writers must adapt to digital platforms, creating content for websites, YouTube, and mobile audiences. She stressed that writing is not only creative but also a business skill, empowering writers to influence audiences and compete responsibly in a global space.

KEY TAKEAWAY: “Writing today is both a creative and business skill. Adapt, refine, and let your work speak with clarity and impact.

Celina Chinwemmeri Ikechukwu, the Authors’ Hub rapporteur, is a student and an award-winning writer.

REPORT ON THE AUTHORS' HUB MONTHLY PANEL DISCUSSION

By Celina Chinwemmeri Ikechukwu

INTRODUCTION

The Authors' Hub 12th Monthly Panel Discussion, themed **Interrogating the Absence of Emerging African Writers in School Curricula**, was held on 25th April 2026, from 4:30 PM to 6:00 PM via Google Meet.

The session which had a large turnout of attendees, brought together accomplished writers, scholars, and literary practitioners to discuss the absence of emerging African writers in school curricula.

The discussion was moderated by **Miss Rashidat Ajakaye**, an award-winning scholar, poet, and skilled moderator, she founded STRIDA Club, connecting writers across ten countries, and is author of *Shattered Shadows of Youths* and over 1,000 poems. She is a Graduate Assistant in the Department of Language, Arts and Social Science Education at Lagos State University, Ojo. She made history as the first First-Class graduate in English Education in over four decades (2022/2023). During the session, she brought both academic depth and practical literary experience to the conversation, steering the session with clarity and insight.

The panel featured an array of respectable speakers:

Prof. Yusuf Adamu is a distinguished scholar, award-winning poet and novelist, Fellow of ANA, and professor of Medical Geography at Bayero University, Kano. He has built a formidable academic career with extensive research on health, environment, and society, and authored over twenty books, including novels, poetry, and scholarly works, blending science and literature. He has also served as Head of Department and Director of Bayero University Press, earning recognition as a Fulbright Fellow and member of the Nigerian Academy of Letters.

Dr. Ahmed Wada Ikaka is a seasoned administrator and literary figure who served as a Director at the National Youth Service Corps (NYSC). Renowned for his disciplined leadership, he contributed significantly to youth development and institutional efficiency within the scheme. As a writer, he is noted for insightful works that engage social and moral issues, blending administrative experience with reflective, nation-oriented thought.

Prof. Segun Adekoya is a distinguished academic, writer, and mentor who taught for many years in the Department of English at Obafemi Awolowo University. A professor of Literature, he has produced influential critical works that deepen understanding of African literature and culture. Through decades of teaching and supervision, he has mentored numerous scholars and writers, earning recognition as a leading voice in literary criticism in Nigeria and beyond.

Prof. Ngozi Chuma Udeh is a renowned academic, writer, and public administrator. A professor of English and literary studies, she has contributed significantly to scholarship,

research, and mentorship in Nigerian universities. As a writer, she has produced critical works enriching African literary discourse. She serves as Commissioner for Education in Anambra State, where she has advanced educational reforms, strengthened academic standards, and promoted policies aimed at improving access, quality, and institutional development.

Bishop Sahr Isaac Peterson is a well known Sierra Leonean poet, writer, and dynamic creative voice recognised for his impact across literary and public-speaking spaces. He has received accolades including the Global Writing Company Award (2019) and Intercontinental Writers Award (2025). Academically trained in theology, creative writing, and linguistics, he studied at the University of the People, USA. Having grown up and served in Ghana, he now leads as CEO of the Coalition of Public Speakers & Modern Writers, while working as an English consultant, tutor, and pastor.

The session was hosted by **Sumaila Isah Umaisha**, founder and coordinator of Authors' Hub.

The moderator formally opened the session by welcoming the panelists and participants. She introduced the discussion theme, “**Interrogating the Absence of Emerging African Writers in School Curricula,**” and noted its relevance to contemporary literary development, cultural representation, and educational reform.

She proceeded to introduce the distinguished panelists, highlighting their contributions to literature, scholarship, and cultural discourse. After briefly reflecting on the significance of the topic and appreciating **Mr. Sumaila Isah Umaisha** for hosting the session, she formally commenced the discussion by directing the first question to the opening panelist.

PROF. YUSUF ADAMU

Responding to the opening question of "How can interdisciplinary approaches strengthen the case for including African writers in traditionally canon-driven curricula?" Prof. Yusuf Adamu emphasized that writers from diverse academic backgrounds, especially the sciences and social sciences, bring valuable perspectives that enrich literary discourse. According to him, interdisciplinary approaches combine analytical insight with creative expression, thereby expanding the way literature is studied and appreciated.

He argued that the exclusion of emerging African writers from school curricula is closely tied to the question of canonization: “*How do we canonize? Who do we canonize? Who do we give a read?*” He explained that many institutions continue to rely on already established names while neglecting newer voices, often because educators and critics are more familiar with older texts.

Prof. Adamu noted that this dependence on traditional literary canons limits innovation and representation. He stressed the need for scholars, critics, and curriculum developers who are willing to research, evaluate, and promote contemporary African writers.

He concluded that unless deliberate efforts are made to recognize and include new voices, the visibility of emerging writers within formal education systems will remain “very elusive.”

DR. AHMED WADAIKAKA

Addressing the impact of excluding emerging African writers from school curricula, Dr. Ikaka drew from his experience in youth development through the NYSC, where intellectual and moral growth remain central objectives. He described literature as a vital tool for shaping young minds, noting that it strengthens critical thinking, analytical ability, emotional intelligence, and problem-solving skills, while keeping youths aware of events within their environment.

On moral development, he explained that literature serves as a mirror of society and a guide for navigating life's complexities. According to him, texts help young people develop empathy, ethical reasoning, sound judgment, and the ability to make responsible choices.

Dr. Ikaka observed that many older canonical texts largely focus on precolonial, colonial, and early post-colonial struggles. While these works remain historically valuable, he argued that overreliance on them creates a disconnect with present realities. "The society is dynamic, and the younger generation of Africans must move with the new order."

He stressed that contemporary writers are better positioned to address pressing modern concerns such as corruption, insecurity, poverty, cybercrime, poor education, abuse of power, and economic dependency. For this reason, he strongly supported the inclusion of emerging African writers in curricula, stating that "the knowledge and wisdom of modern characters are found among the new generation writers."

On institutional reforms, Dr. Ikaka recommended regular curriculum reviews every three years to accommodate newer texts, greater involvement of state ministries in selecting local authors, and policies requiring examining bodies such as WAEC, NECO, JAMB, and NERDC to include a percentage of works by new writers. He also called for publishing grants, expanded literary awards, stronger online platforms for publicity, and annual engagements between writers, educational agencies, and government stakeholders.

PROF. SEGUN ADEKOYA

Prof. Segun Adekoya delivered a wide-ranging and intellectually rigorous intervention on literary criticism, canon formation, and the place of emerging African writers in school curricula. He began by explaining that critical criteria are the standards used to assess literary works. These include elements such as plot, characterization, language, rhythm, theme, setting, and point of view. Critics, he noted, examine whether these devices are effectively used and whether they produce a coherent, meaningful, and aesthetically satisfying work. In his words, literary judgment concerns "what is written, how it is written, and the value of what is written."

Prof. Adekoya observed that critics remain divided on whether literary standards are universal or relative. Some believe enduring writers such as Homer, Sophocles, *Euripides*, *Aristophanes*, *Chaucer*, *Shakespeare*, *Milton*, and *Alexander Pope* achieved greatness by mastering timeless artistic principles. Others argue that values are culture-bound and constantly shifting. He stressed that while classical principles remain useful, contemporary writers must respond truthfully to present realities. Citing Ola Rotimi's *The Gods Are Not to Blame*, he noted that though the play follows Aristotelian structure, it places responsibility for tragedy on human actions rather than divine forces. He also referenced **Wole Soyinka's** *"Dawn"* as an example of *innovation within inherited forms*.

According to him, modern society has altered the nature of tragedy itself. Science and technology have weakened older beliefs in fate and divinity, while new global realities often make suffering appear absurd or “comically tragic,” as seen in **Franz Kafka’s** *Metamorphosis*. Yet he warned that modern inventions, including artificial intelligence, while promising liberation, also carry destructive potential.

Turning directly to the panel theme, Prof. Adekoya argued that it is inaccurate to claim emerging African writers are entirely absent from curricula. Rather, they are underrepresented. He cited current WAEC texts such as Pede Hollist’s *So the Path Does Not Die*, Elma Shaw’s *Redemption Road*, Bosede Ademilua-Afolayan’s *Once Upon an Elephant*, Elizabeth L. A. Kamara’s “New Tongue,” and S. O. H. Afriyie-Vidza’s “Hearty Garlands.” At tertiary level, he noted that institutions already have room to introduce newer voices. He referenced writers such as Chimamanda Adichie, Chika Unigwe, Helen Oyeyemi, Helon Habila, Kaine Agary, Tess Onwueme, Onyeka Francisca Onyekuba, Chinelo Okparanta, Chinyere Grace Okafor, Chigozie Obioma, Elnathan John, and Segun Afolabi as examples of contemporary authors already gaining curricular presence.

Prof. Adekoya emphasized that selecting texts is never simple. Space, time, relevance, and quality all matter. Literary judgment, he said, often includes subjectivity, reminding participants that “Beauty is in the eye of the beholder.” He further noted that access remains a major barrier. Many writers self-publish, but weak distribution systems mean books do not circulate across Africa. Teachers cannot teach texts they cannot obtain. He called for stronger public libraries and better publishing networks.

On canon formation, he reminded participants that literary reputation changes with time. Writers once considered “popular” or marginal, like Shakespeare, later entered the canon. “The world is a marketplace of ideas,” he declared, where newcomers must compete for space and recognition.

He therefore advised emerging writers not to lose hope or become impatient when society fails to understand them immediately. They should continue refining their craft, mastering the rules before attempting to break them. While many younger writers are bold and confrontational in tone, he noted that subtlety remains one of art’s highest strengths.

In one of his most striking remarks, he lamented that “art has lost its ability to speak,” urging writers to restore literature’s power to challenge, illuminate, and endure.

He concluded that the surest path for emerging writers is excellence, persistence, and confidence: not shortcuts or connections, but the “craggy and rugged road” that leads to unquestionable greatness.

PROF. NGOZI CHUMA-UDEH

Prof. Ngozi Chuma-Udeh approached the discussion from an educational and practical standpoint, stressing that the issue is not the absence of African writers alone, but how curricula are structured and managed within a limited academic system. She noted that Africa and Nigeria already possess many gifted writers, including globally recognized voices such as Chimamanda

Ngozi Adichie and numerous others. However, she cautioned against overloading students with too many texts, observing that “there are so many wonderful writers in Africa... if the children are to read all of them, it’s going to be too Herculean for them.”*

According to her, education operates within a system of macro and micro structures, where books are reviewed periodically and selected according to each level of learning. She maintained that African literature and African writers should continue to be adequately represented through these review processes.

Speaking candidly, she remarked: “I am not going to be sentimental about it.” She explained that many writers strongly desire to have their books prescribed for secondary school classes, but curricular inclusion must go beyond personal ambition.

Prof. Ngozi emphasized that at every stage of text selection, indigenous works should be intentionally represented: “Between every set of books, at least one of our own books should be included, especially within the school curriculum.” She then moved to what she considered a deeper solution. Literature, she said, should not be written merely to enter the curriculum. “Literature is not life, but literature is an imitation of life. Therefore, we should not write only for the sake of the curriculum; we should write for a general readership.” For a book to attain lasting relevance, she argued, it must speak beyond the classroom. An engineer, doctor, farmer, and ordinary reader should all be able to connect with it. In her words, “That is the true representation of reality.” She identified three qualities that elevate a book to greatness:

It is passed from one generation to another and continues to be valued. It earns enduring acclaim over time. It transcends geography, so readers across cultures appreciate it. As she illustrated, a Chinese reader, South American reader, or Australian reader should be able to encounter the text and say, “Wow, this is beautiful.” She concluded by reminding participants that curriculum space is limited. While many talented writers deserve recognition, not every worthy book can be included at once. She referenced examination bodies such as WAEC and NECO, noting that several African texts are already in use. The real challenge, therefore, is not inclusion alone, but fair selection, quality, and broad relevance.

BISHOP SAHR ISAAC PETERSON

Responding with passion and conviction, Bishop Sahr Isaac Peterson affirmed that emerging African writers are still struggling for recognition, not only within school curricula, but within wider cultural, educational, and literary systems.

Speaking from his experience in Sierra Leone and the broader West African space, he identified one of the greatest obstacles as the decline of reading culture. According to him, the rise of social media has shifted the attention of many young people away from books, with a large percentage now more engaged online than in sustained reading. This, he said, has weakened literary growth, readership, and intellectual culture.

He also questioned the continued dominance of foreign texts in African classrooms. While clarifying that he was not opposed to William Shakespeare, he argued that many classical texts contain language and expressions unfamiliar to younger African learners. Terms such as “thou”

and “thee” may be difficult for children at foundational levels, making literary engagement less accessible.

Peterson maintained that if African writers such as *Chinua Achebe, Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie*, and others had been consistently prioritized earlier, foreign writers would not have occupied such overwhelming space in African reading culture.

A central part of his intervention focused on identity and originality. He argued that Africa has been gradually distanced from its own voice through inherited systems that undervalue indigenous creativity. In one of his strongest remarks, he declared: “We have been beaten out of our Africanness.”

Using the story of *Kunta Kinte* in *Roots*, whose name was changed to Toby, he illustrated how identity can be erased through imposed systems. He linked this directly to literature, stating that African writers are often pressured to abandon their authentic styles, names, and creative expressions in order to fit foreign expectations.

He lamented the growing culture of imitation among creatives, saying: “The writing system, we are all becoming copycats.” He further explained with a memorable analogy: “Just like an artist who performs another person’s song, you may appreciate it, but when it is not originally yours, the rightful owner remains the one who deserves the recognition. That is how Africa is.” According to him, African societies often celebrate borrowed forms while neglecting originality. Many writers are praised for writing in foreign styles rather than developing their own voices and techniques.

Drawing from his own struggles within Sierra Leone’s literary space, he hinted at the difficulty younger writers face in entering or reforming structures that are slow to recognize new voices. He also expressed concern about weak coordination among literary institutions and inconsistent educational reforms across parts of West Africa, where new subjects or curriculum changes are sometimes introduced without clear planning or long-term direction.

While careful not to condemn his country, he acknowledged that many of the literary works currently gaining broader recognition in the region are coming from Nigerian writers who are intentionally developing their craft and engaging seriously with literature.

Peterson therefore called for unity among African writers, scholars, and institutions. In his words, “If African work should be known to the world, we should be united and work together to make them recognized.” He urged Africans to build a common literary vision, promoting their writers, originality, ideas, and creative methods, so that the continent can speak confidently through literature rather than remain under the shadow of others.

CONTRIBUTIONS FROM PARTICIPANTS:

MALLAM DENJA ABDULLAHI

Mallam Denja Abdullahi highlighted systemic gaps in how literary texts are selected and integrated into Nigeria’s educational curriculum, stressing that the core challenge lies in weak

coordination among key gatekeeping institutions.

He observed that there is a disconnect between policy, implementation, and practice, noting that although revised curricula exist, many schools still rely on outdated versions. In his words, “the gatekeepers; those who determine what a nation presents, are disconnected.” This, he argued, reflects a broader failure of inter-agency collaboration and governmental follow-through.

According to him, curriculum content is shaped by multiple stakeholders, including policymakers in education, literary scholars, publishers, and prize institutions. However, he emphasized that without a clear national framework, these actors operate without cohesion or direction.

He raised fundamental policy questions: What do we want our children to read? Who determines this? Who assesses it? And who ensures implementation? For him, the absence of a clear literary and educational policy is the root of inconsistency in curriculum design.

Mallam Denja also drew attention to weaknesses within assessment systems such as Education Resource Centres, noting that decisions are sometimes influenced by lobbying rather than merit. As a result, substandard works may enter the curriculum while high-quality Nigerian texts are overlooked.

He stressed that effective selection cannot rely on advocacy alone but must be guided by transparent, rigorous evaluation processes involving qualified literary experts and experienced writers.

He concluded that Nigeria’s literary education system suffers from a lack of structure and alignment between policy, assessment, and implementation. Without this coordination, he warned, “all kinds of books find their way into the education system,” many of which fail to reflect national priorities or address contemporary societal challenges.

Ultimately, he called for a clearly defined literary and educational policy that determines not just what is read in schools, but why it is read, and how it serves the development of society.

DR. AWELE ILUSANMI, FANA

Dr. Awele, building on earlier submissions, emphasized that beyond policies, frameworks, and institutional discussions, the central issue is care and responsibility.

Aligning with **Mallam Denja’s** point on systemic gaps, she stressed that meaningful reform must begin from a place of genuine commitment. In her words, “Do we really care enough?” She argued that until those responsible for education and literary selection take ownership with sincerity, structural reforms alone will not yield meaningful change.

She noted that the problem is not only about selecting or “logging” books into curricula, but about ensuring that the right people—those who truly care about educational quality—are involved in the process.

Dr. Awele further emphasized that standards must not be compromised. She insisted on prioritizing quality over mediocrity, stating that Nigeria must avoid “low products” in its educational system.

She concluded that if stakeholders genuinely care enough to make the right decisions, strengthen institutions, and prioritize quality education, then the broader outcome will be a more effective system and ultimately a better society.

PRISCANWOKORIE

PRISCA noted that many quality textbooks are often absent from school curricula not because they lack merit, but because of limited visibility, access, or lack of institutional connections. She explained that even suitable books may be excluded if the authors or publishers are not well positioned within the system.

She stressed that curriculum improvement cannot depend on individuals alone, but requires a collective and structured effort to ensure that good educational materials are fairly considered and adopted in schools.

PANELISTS FINAL REMARKS

PROF. YUSUFADAMU

Prof. Yusuf noted that contemporary African voices are not truly absent, as literature now exists in both print and digital forms. However, he stressed that several structural challenges limit their visibility and impact.

He identified key issues including: Very small print runs (often under 1,000 copies) with little or no reprints Poor book distribution and low purchasing culture, leading to limited readership Weak promotion and visibility of new works

Inadequate book reviewing culture, causing delays or absence of critical engagement He further explained that efforts to document and highlight local writers are ongoing, including collaborations across disciplines. However, he acknowledged that attempts to spotlight certain voices can sometimes generate tension within academic and literary spaces.

He concluded that improving visibility, promotion, and documentation systems is essential for integrating contemporary African literature more effectively into academic and public reading spaces.

DR. AHMED WADAIKAKA

Dr. Ahmed emphasized that the goal is not to replace canonical texts but to create space for emerging African voices within the curriculum. He used a simple analogy, noting that reading the same type of content repeatedly is like “eating rice every day,” which becomes monotonous, stressing the need for variety in literature.

He proposed key institutional strategies, including: Regular curriculum review (ideally every 3 years) to include contemporary writers Greater flexibility for state ministries of education to

select texts from emerging authors

Decentralization of curriculum selection to reflect regional and local literary realities He further argued that just as past educational reforms allowed structured language teaching systems, similar openness should now be applied to literary inclusion.

He concluded that a more flexible and decentralized approach would make the curriculum more inclusive, dynamic, and responsive to contemporary African realities.

PROF. SEGUN ADEKOYA

Prof. Segun stressed that the literary space is now heavily influenced by economic and political realities, where publishing has become highly commercialised and competitive, making it difficult for emerging writers to break through without strong support structures.

He noted that political and economic narratives often dominate public discourse, reflected in what he described as *Buharinomics*, *Abachanomics*, and even *Tinubunomics*,” which illustrate how political contexts shape writing, publishing, and attention in the literary space.

He recommended practical solutions such as: Increasing annual literary awards Ensuring that winning works are adopted into school curricula He also raised concern about the decline in reading culture, linking it to the influence of social media and digital distractions. According to him, “this Gen Z era” has significantly shifted attention away from books, as many young people spend more time on phones engaging with entertainment content than reading.

He concluded that while the challenges are significant, strengthening recognition systems and rebuilding reading culture are essential for sustaining literary growth and relevance.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Curriculum and canon inclusion is structured but limited: African writers are present but underrepresented due to selection systems, institutional constraints, and weak coordination among education bodies, publishers, and policymakers.
- Writing today demands both craft and strategy: Emerging writers must focus on strong storytelling while also understanding audience, visibility, marketing, and publishing as part of a growing creative economy.
- Sustaining African literature requires systemic and cultural support: Improved reading culture, stronger policies, better promotion/distribution systems, and intentional collaboration among stakeholders are essential for literary growth and global recognition.

Celina Chinwemmeri Ikehukwu, the Authors’ Hub rapporteur, is a student and an award-winning writer.

REPORT ON THE MAY EDITION OF AUTHORS' HUB MONTHLY PANEL DISCUSSION

By Celina Chinwemmeri Ikechukwu

INTRODUCTION

The Authors' Hub 13th Monthly Panel Discussion, themed Examining the Decline of Reading Culture in Contemporary Society was held on 30th April 2026, from 4:30 PM to 6:00 PM via Google Meet.

The well-attended session convened established writers, scholars, and literary practitioners to examine the prevailing low reading culture in Nigeria and beyond.

The discussion was moderated by Mr. Yanwaidi Emma Zwahu, a seasoned media and communication professional with over two decades of experience in broadcasting, content creation, and training. He is the creator and presenter of the literary programme Chips and Slices on FRCN Supreme FM, Kaduna, where he has mentored emerging writers, and has also produced civic and governance programmes for both national and international organisations. A columnist and literary activist, Zwahu's extensive engagements in media and literature equipped him to guide the session with depth, structure, and clarity, enriching the discourse.

The panel featured an array of respectable speakers:

DR. ABDULLAHI ISMAILA AHMAD is a poet, short story writer, essayist, and influential literary administrator with a wide range of published works across poetry, fiction, and critical essays. He has served in key leadership positions within the Association of Nigerian Authors, shaping literary development and advocacy. He is also an editor whose work has significantly contributed to Nigeria's contemporary literary and intellectual landscape.

MR. ERIC AGYEMANG is a renowned Ghanaian filmmaker driven by a deep passion for storytelling. He is self-motivated and embraces meaningful challenges, setting standards that benefit both himself and others. A lover of nature, he values creativity and purpose. He is an artist who upholds dedication, discipline, integrity, and a positive mindset as essential to progress, believing that lasting change begins with brightening one's immediate environment.

LADY EJIRO UMUKORO is an award-winning author and globally recognised investigative media executive known for impactful storytelling. Her acclaimed Distortion series, including The Distortion of Hadassah, blends literature with journalism to address caste bias, human trafficking, and press censorship. A speaker with PEN Nigeria, she advocates creative freedom and press rights, using fiction as a tool to inspire reform and shape national discourse.

DR. FOLUKE ALIYU is an Associate Professor of Literature in English at the University of Ilorin. Her scholarship spans feminism and gender studies, literary aesthetics and criticism across poetry, prose, and drama, as well as oral literature, cultural studies, and semiotics. She also has a wealth of professional experience in banking and broadcast journalism, enriching her

interdisciplinary approach to literary studies and critical discourse.

PROF. MUSA IDRIS OKPANACHI is a poet, literary scholar, and critic well known for his influential contributions to contemporary African poetry. He is the author of *Eaters of the Living*, which won the Association of Nigerian Authors/Cadbury Prize for Poetry and was shortlisted for the Nigeria Prize for Literature. His other works, which also explore society, power, and human condition, earning him critical acclaim, are: *From the Margins of Paradise*, *Music of the Dead* and *Silence of Time*.

The session was hosted by **SUMAILA ISAH UMAISHA**, founder and coordinator of Authors' Hub.

THE DISCUSSION

The moderator formally opened the session by welcoming the panelists and participants, and introducing the theme. He proceeded to introduce the distinguished panelists, acknowledging their contributions to literature, scholarship, and cultural discourse. The session was then officially set in motion.

DR. ABDULLAHI ISMAILAAHMAD

Responding to the question on the decline of reading culture among young people, Dr. Abdullahi Ismaila Ahmad urged caution against making simplistic assumptions. In his words, "We must approach the issue of declining reading culture with caution and avoid blame at will." He noted that while literary traditions such as Onitsha Market Literature and Soyayya literature once attracted large youth readerships through accessible and relatable content, these traditions eventually weakened under the influence of technology and social media.

According to him, the major factors responsible for the decline include the absence of a sustained reading tradition, the rise of the internet and social media, the shortage of engaging literary works targeted at young readers, declining publishing standards, and worsening economic conditions that limit access to books. He argued that many contemporary works are often written for foreign audiences and may not adequately reflect the realities and interests of local young readers.

On rebuilding reading culture, Dr. Ahmad advocated deliberate and collaborative interventions. He called for greater investment in reading programmes by governments, private organisations, and philanthropists, stressing that reading initiatives should be actively funded and incentivised. He also encouraged educational institutions to promote creative works among students and recommended the revival of influential literary series such as the *Pacesetter* and *African Writers Series*.

He further urged the Association of Nigerian Authors (ANA) to serve as a focal point for reading advocacy and suggested that literary prizes, particularly the NLNG Prize, should incorporate structured reading programmes that encourage schools and universities to adopt award-winning books. According to him, such measures would ensure that important literary works remain

visible and continue to inspire new generations of readers.

DR. FOLUKE ALIYU

Dr. Foluke Aliyu acknowledged that technology has revolutionised access to books, journals, and research materials through digital libraries and online platforms. However, she argued that access alone does not create readers. In her words, “what technology cannot do is to change the attitude of the student towards actually reading these materials.” She expressed concern that many students now bypass the intellectual process of reading, often relying on copied materials rather than engaging critically with texts. She noted that even with audiobooks and other digital formats, many lack the concentration and attention span required for meaningful learning.

Addressing solutions, she advocated innovative teaching and assessment methods that make reading more engaging and rewarding. Drawing from her classroom practice, she stated, “I encourage students to give me their own understanding of literary works. No answer is considered wrong.” By rewarding critical and original responses, she encourages students to read, think independently, and participate actively.

Drawing from her own teaching experience, she noted that students must be encouraged to think independently rather than rely on ready-made answers. “The questions I give, you can't find them online,” she remarked, emphasizing the importance of critical thinking and personal engagement with literary works.

Beyond the classroom, Dr. Aliyu, maintained that reversing the decline in reading culture requires collective action. While schools already have resources such as libraries, literary clubs, and reading associations, she stressed the need for broader societal reorientation. She called on corporate organisations to sponsor literature-based competitions and reading initiatives, while government should strengthen literary education, including making Nigerian Literature a compulsory subject in secondary schools.

She also highlighted the role of parents in nurturing readers through deliberate support, creating reading time, discussing books with their children, and rewarding reading habits. According to her, reading remains essential to the growth and progress of any society, and rebuilding that culture requires commitment from all stakeholders.

PROF. MUSA IDRIS OKPANACHI

Prof. Musa Idris Okpanachi linked the decline in reading culture to broader social and economic realities. He described reading as a deep and active engagement with texts that thrives under favourable conditions, arguing that critical reading is often an intellectual luxury in societies burdened by hardship. According to him, economic difficulties, insecurity, and psychological stress have eroded the peace of mind required for sustained reading, while the rising cost of books has further limited access. In his memorable words, “one cannot read on an empty stomach.”

He warned that declining reading habits have serious consequences for society's ability to think

critically about social and political realities. As fewer people engage with books, there is a growing tendency to rely on shortcuts rather than original thought. He observed that when knowledge is not rewarded, many begin to ask, "After reading, then what?" For him, the erosion of reading culture contributes directly to weak critical consciousness and poor leadership, maintaining that "a reading nation is a leading nation." On the role of African writers and poets in the digital age, Prof. Okpanachi argued that literary stakeholders must adapt to changing reading habits rather than resist them. He noted that younger generations are increasingly drawn to platforms such as TikTok, Instagram, and Facebook, making long-form reading less attractive than it once was. As a result, writers must explore alternative formats including audiobooks, podcasts, and shorter digital adaptations capable of reaching modern audiences.

He also emphasised the urgent need to preserve Africa's rich storytelling traditions. Drawing attention to the vast reservoir of folktales and oral narratives that remain undocumented, he warned that valuable cultural knowledge is disappearing with the passing of older generations. Echoing a well-known proverb, he observed that when an elder dies, it is often "like a library burning down." He therefore called for deliberate efforts to document, transcribe, digitise, and promote African stories so that they remain accessible to future generations.

LADY EJIRO UMUKORO

Lady Ejiro Umukoro argued that socially conscious literature remains one of the most powerful tools for creating awareness and inspiring transformation, particularly among young readers. She emphasised that people naturally gravitate towards stories that reflect the realities around them, noting that literature becomes impactful when it speaks truthfully to society through engaging storytelling.

According to her, readers connect deeply with narratives when they can see themselves, their communities, and their struggles reflected in the characters and events. She explained that the strength of socially conscious literature lies in its ability to entertain while provoking thought. Rather than merely delivering messages, writers should craft stories that engage readers emotionally and intellectually. In her words, "Literature should make them challenge long-held biases, and break down harmful misconceptions and taboos. Through relatable characters and compelling narratives, readers are encouraged to reflect on their choices, aspirations, and social realities."

On the challenges of short attention span, Umukoro maintained that institutions already possess many of the resources needed to encourage reading, including libraries, literary clubs, and student associations. However, she stressed that educators must adopt more creative and innovative teaching methods to stimulate genuine engagement with texts.

For Umukoro, the challenge facing authors today is not simply competition from social media and fast content, but finding ways to tell meaningful stories that can both entertain and provoke reflection. She argued that if writers can create narratives that people genuinely connect with, readers will continue to make time for books despite the distractions of the digital age.

MR. ERIC AGYEMANG

Reflecting on his journey as a filmmaker born in the 1980s, Mr. Eric Agyemang noted that the film industry of the 1990s and early 2000s was far less saturated with social media influence, allowing storytelling to stand more independently as a primary source of entertainment and reflection. He observed that today's digital environment has changed attention patterns, but it has also expanded the tools available for storytelling. He explained that his work as a filmmaker is rooted in storytelling that feels real and relatable. For him, film is not just entertainment but a way of bringing lived experiences to life in ways audiences can connect with emotionally and intellectually. He highlighted the use of short films as an effective medium for this purpose, especially in the digital age where attention spans are shorter.

Sharing from personal experience, he referenced a short film he produced some years ago about a young boy going through emotional difficulty and discouragement. The story, he said, was designed to reflect real struggles young people face and to show how storytelling can validate experiences and inspire resilience. He concluded that whether through short films or full-length productions, the essence of storytelling remains the same: to present relatable human experiences in a way that engages, educates, and emotionally connects with audiences.

CONTRIBUTIONS FROM PARTICIPANTS:

PROF. OLUSEGUN ADEKOYA

Prof. Olusegun Adekoya located the decline in reading culture within broader socio-economic pressures and shifting value systems. He argued that in many African societies today, "bread and butter" realities have taken precedence over intellectual development, stressing that "once we resolve bread and butter issues, we will begin to build a living culture of love in our society." He illustrated this with a Yoruba proverb which stresses that basic survival needs often override the call for deeper intellectual or cultural nourishment.

He emphasized that materialism has overtaken societal values, noting that many young people, including undergraduates, are now more focused on money-making ventures such as trading and online income generation than on formal education. In his view, this is partly driven by frustration over unemployment and the perceived lack of returns from education, which shifts attention away from reading and learning.

Prof. Adekoya also highlighted the dominance of digital distractions and short-form content, which he described as contributing to "attention deficit" in contemporary society. He observed that young people are increasingly drawn to fast, consumable content such as skits, music, and social media, making it difficult to sustain engagement with long-form texts like novels.

He concluded that meaningful reading requires discipline, sacrifice, and willpower, noting that the current environment, shaped by constant distractions and the pursuit of quick financial gain, has weakened society's capacity for deep, sustained reading.

DR. KABURA ZAKAMA

Kabura Zakama emphasised that rebuilding a reading culture must begin with children, stressing that reading habits are formed early through direct engagement at home and in school. Drawing from personal experience, he recalled how reading with siblings and older family members helped shape early literacy before formal schooling.

He expressed concern that modern family life has shifted toward digital distraction, noting that it is now common to see entire households absorbed in individual phone use rather than reading or conversation. In his view, this has weakened intergenerational reading practices that once helped sustain literary culture. He stressed that parents and guardians must actively read with children and encourage imitation and gradual independence in reading. He shared an example of how his own child developed interest in reading by observing him and a sibling, reinforcing his belief that children learn best through exposure and participation.

Kabura also highlighted the importance of age-appropriate literature, raising concern about the current shortage of engaging children's books and called on writers to produce more literature tailored to younger readers. He concluded that reading culture is not being built anew. It must be "rebuilt" by returning to foundational practices: reading with children, encouraging early literacy, and expanding access to children's literature.

DR. AWELE ILUSANMI, FANA

Dr. Awele Ilusanmi reinforced the central concern of the discussion, the decline of reading culture, attributing part of the challenge to the rise of the internet and digital distractions. She observed that both young people and adults are now less engaged with sustained reading, as attention has shifted toward fast, screen-based content.

Despite this, she maintained that there is still hope for rebuilding and strengthening reading culture if deliberate efforts are made across homes, schools, and institutions. She cautioned against extreme or simplistic solutions, emphasising that the issue is not to "ban" digital tools but to rethink how reading is promoted within a digitally driven society.

Her contribution underscored the need for intentional strategies that reintroduce reading as a daily habit and cultural practice rather than an occasional academic requirement.

MR. BM DZUKOGI

Mal. BM Dzukogi commended the ongoing efforts by individuals and institutions working to promote reading culture, noting that sustaining such initiatives is essential if the decline is to be reversed. He emphasised that building a reading culture requires active participation and support rather than passive observation.

He referenced long-standing interventions, including annual support and funding directed toward literary bodies such as the Association of Nigerian Authors, as well as corporate contributions like the Nigeria LNG (NLNG) initiatives, which have helped sustain reading

promotion programmes and writers' forums over the years. Dzukogi stressed that beyond institutional funding, the most critical intervention is early sensitisation, particularly involving parents and teachers in cultivating reading habits from childhood. He observed that children who are properly introduced to reading early are more likely to develop lasting literary habits.

He concluded that reading culture must be intentionally "indoctrinated" or nurtured from the foundational level through coordinated efforts by families, schools, and literary organisations, rather than left to chance.

MR. IGWE

Mr. Igwe, speaking briefly as a young student, highlighted the declining interest in reading among his peers, noting that many young people now perceive reading as unimportant compared to the pursuit of online income and constant phone use.

He also raised concern about the growing dependence on artificial intelligence and digital tools for academic work, which he believes is reducing students' motivation to read and think independently. He suggested the creation of structured communities or groups of young readers, where interested students can be brought together, guided, and encouraged to build consistent reading habits.

DR. AHMED WADA IKAKA

Dr. Ahmed reflected on the contrast between the past and the present reading cultures, noting that earlier generations read more consistently because books were central to schooling and access to digital distractions was limited. He recalled how discipline around reading was stronger in secondary school, where engagement with texts was more structured and enforced.

He observed that today's environment has changed significantly due to the rise of gadgets and social media. While acknowledging the shift, he argued that society must adapt by actively promoting reading through modern channels rather than resisting them.

According to him, much of what young people consume online is entertainment-driven rather than educational, often focused on gossip and lifestyle content, with limited exposure to developmental or intellectual material. He stressed that parents have a critical role to play in guiding what children access and consume. He further called for stronger institutional and community interventions, including sponsorships, literary prizes, book competitions, and structured reading initiatives. He emphasised the need to produce more relevant content and create incentives that encourage young people to read and engage meaningfully with literature.

KEY TAKEAWAYS FROM PANELISTS

MR. ERIC AGYEMANG

* Film and social media should be seen as allies, not threats, to reading culture.

* Visual storytelling (especially short films) can bridge young audiences back to literature.*

Creatives should use digital platforms to spark emotional connection and curiosity toward books.

DR. FOLUKE ALIYU

- * Technology improves access to texts but does not guarantee engagement or deep reading.
- * The real challenge is student attitude and declining attention span, not availability of materials.
- * Education systems must adopt innovative, critical-thinking-based teaching and assessment methods.

LADY EJIRO UMUKORO

- * Reading culture can be strengthened through innovative teaching and assessment methods in universities.
- * Literature should be socially conscious, relatable, and emotionally engaging to remain relevant.
- * Writers should use storytelling to entertain while also provoking critical reflection and awareness.

DR. ABDULLAHI ISMAILAAHMAD

- * A sustained African reading culture has never been fully institutionalised; it is largely individual-driven.
- * Decline is linked to digital disruption, weak publishing systems, poor promotion, and economic hardship.
- * Solutions lie in policy support, institutional reading programs, revived publishing traditions, and structured literary advocacy.

PROF. MUSA IDRIS OKPANACHI

- * Reading is deeply affected by economic hardship and psychological pressure, which reduce intellectual engagement.
- * Declining reading habits contribute to weak critical thinking and societal leadership challenges.
- * Literature must adapt through digital formats and documentation of African oral and cultural knowledge.

Celina Chinwemmeri Ikechukwu, the Authors' Hub rapporteur, is a student and an award-winning writer.

REPORT ON THE AUTHORS' HUB MONTHLY PANEL DISCUSSION

By Celina Chinwemmeri Ikechukwu

INTRODUCTION

The Authors' Hub 15th Monthly Panel Discussion, themed ***Literary Networking: The Benefits and Challenges of Online Literary Communities*** was held on 27th of June 2026, from 4:30 PM to 6:00 PM via Google Meet.

The well-attended session, brought together accomplished writers, scholars, and literary practitioners to explore the creative and professional dimensions of writing, along with the benefits and challenges they present, with special focus on helping emerging writers navigate online literary communities with ease for sustainable, long-term careers.

Mrs. Zuwaira Halilu, the Moderator, is an experienced educator, author, and literary advocate from Maiduguri, Borno State. As Head of the English Language Department in a public school, she is dedicated to academic excellence and the development of young minds. Her writing explores themes of resilience, empowerment, and social reflection. A passionate promoter of literary culture, she mentors emerging writers and currently serves as Chairperson of the Borno State Chapter of the Association of Nigerian Authors (ANA).

The panel featured an impressive lineup of distinguished speakers:

DR. EZIWHO EMENIKE AZUNWO, popularly known as the Academic Rabbi, is an Associate Professor of Literary Criticism and Playwriting at Rivers State University and one of Nigeria's most prolific contemporary dramatists, with over 140 published plays to his credit. A distinguished critic and theorist who formerly served as Acting Head of Theatre and Film Studies, his scholarship interrogates social transformation, women's empowerment, and the portrayal of domestic violence in Nigerian video films.

MR. JERRY ADESEWO is an accomplished playwright, theatre producer, director, and cultural administrator whose contributions have significantly shaped contemporary theatre practice in Nigeria. As Founder and Artistic Director of Arojah Royal Theatre, he has led numerous acclaimed stage productions, adaptations, festivals, and international cultural collaborations. A widely published cultural journalist and respected dramaturge, he has represented Nigeria at major theatre festivals across Europe, Asia, and Africa, earning recognition as one of the nation's foremost advocates for theatre development and cultural diplomacy.

AISHA UMAR MUHAMMAD is an accomplished scholar, poet, novelist, and creative writing specialist, holding degrees from Usmanu Danfodiyo University, Sokoto, and Cardiff Metropolitan University, United Kingdom. A lecturer in African Literature, Gender Studies, Ecocriticism, and Creative Writing, she most recently served as Business Editor of the Kebbi Journal of Languages and Literature and as Secretary of the Literary Scholars Association (LSA). Her scholarly and creative works have appeared in both national and international

publications, and she is the author of the novel *Yar Fari*.

MR. EBIKA ANTHONY is a cultural activist, poet, performer, puppeteer, publisher, and arts administrator whose work has significantly advanced literary and performing arts practice. A former National Publicity Secretary (South) of the Association of Nigerian Authors (ANA), he has served as an adjudicator at both the National Festival of Arts and Culture (NAFEST) and the Oyo State Festival of Arts and Culture (OYSFAC). He currently serves as President of Poetry Enclave (POEN), Ibadan, where he remains a leading advocate for cultural development and artistic excellence.

The session was hosted by **SUMAILA ISAH UMAISHA**, founder and coordinator of Authors' Hub.

The moderator formally opened the session by welcoming the panelists and participants, and introducing the theme, "Literary Networking: The Benefits and Challenges of Online Literary Communities," highlighting its relevance to contemporary literary practice, cultural expression, and professional development in the digital age.

She proceeded to introduce the distinguished panelists, acknowledging their contributions to literature, scholarship, and cultural discourse.

The session was then officially set in motion as she directed the first question to the lead panelist, marking the beginning of the discussion.

MR. JERRY ADESEWO

Responding to questions on the importance of online literary communities and the responsibilities of literary organisations, Mr. Jerry Adesewo described virtual literary communities as "one of the most significant developments in contemporary literary culture." He noted that they have democratized access to learning, mentorship, publication opportunities, and global literary conversations, making it possible for an emerging writer in Abuja, Jos, or Makurdi to interact with established authors across Nigeria and beyond without leaving home.

Drawing from his experience with the Association of Nigerian Authors (ANA), Mr. Adesewo identified mentorship and learning as the greatest strengths of literary communities. He recalled how writers in the ANA Abuja Chapter regularly held manuscript critique sessions where completed works were carefully reviewed, discussed, and improved through constructive feedback. According to him, this culture of mentorship played a significant role in the literary success of many writers from the chapter.

He also highlighted networking, collaboration, visibility, accessibility, and motivation as major benefits of online literary spaces. Literary communities, he explained, often become a writer's first audience, bringing together publishers, editors, reviewers, event organisers, and fellow creatives who help refine manuscripts and open doors to new opportunities. He further observed that digital platforms have made it easier than ever for writers to promote their work and reach readers across the world.

Sharing a personal experience, Mr. Adesewo admitted that there was a time he wrote poems but kept them to himself because he lacked confidence. It was through the encouragement of fellow writers that he found the courage to publish his work. "The support, encouragement, and constructive feedback from fellow writers motivated me to grow, improve my craft, and believe in my abilities," he said.

While celebrating these opportunities, he cautioned that online literary communities should complement rather than replace the discipline required to become a good writer. "A writer grows not merely by being visible online, but by consistently developing their craft." He maintained that the best literary communities are those that inspire discipline, encourage critical engagement, and foster genuine artistic growth rather than the pursuit of popularity.

Offering advice to emerging writers, Mr. Adesewo encouraged them to approach literary spaces with patience, humility, and authenticity. "Begin by listening before seeking to be heard," he advised, urging writers to read widely, participate consistently, celebrate the successes of others, remain open to feedback, and focus on building trust instead of merely collecting contacts. He emphasized that lasting literary careers are built through "consistency, humility, and excellence."

Addressing the role of literary organisations and platform administrators, he stressed that their responsibility goes beyond attracting followers. Instead, they should create environments where emerging voices feel welcomed, respected, and challenged to grow through mentorship, constructive criticism, ethical engagement, diversity, and practical opportunities such as masterclasses, competitions, fellowships, collaborative projects, and professional networking. As he aptly put it, "The measure of a literary community is not the size of its membership, but the number of writers whose lives and careers it genuinely transforms."

Mr. Adesewo concluded by acknowledging that digital literary communities also face significant challenges. He expressed concern over the gradual decline of genuine literary criticism, observing that honest feedback is sometimes mistaken for personal attacks, causing many writers to avoid offering sincere critique. He also warned against the growing tendency to place popularity above literary merit, as well as the rise of toxic online exchanges where differing opinions often result in hostility rather than healthy discussion. Using debates surrounding artificial intelligence as an example, he argued that disagreement should encourage meaningful conversation, not personal attacks, reminding participants that "Literature thrives on diverse perspectives, and meaningful conversations can only take place where there is mutual respect."

MRS. AISHA UMAR MUHAMMAD

Responding to questions on inclusivity in online literary communities and the future of digital literary spaces, Mrs. Aisha Umar Muhammad observed that participation in literary communities, whether physical or virtual, is largely "a matter of choice and interest." She acknowledged that many online platforms are commercially driven and often prioritize content that enhances their visibility and sustainability. As a result, writers seeking to build an online presence must approach the digital space strategically, exercising patience, consistency, and

intentional audience-building.

Looking ahead, she affirmed that "digital literature has come to stay," noting that online literary communities will continue to break new ground and explore innovative forms of literary engagement. She encouraged writers to create original, dynamic, and distinctive content capable of reaching a global audience, emphasizing that online platforms often attract far more readers than traditional print publications.

Comparing traditional and digital literary communities, Mrs. Muhammad rejected the notion that the two are in competition. Instead, she described digital literary communities as "an extension and advancement of the traditional one." While online platforms have transformed the way writers interact, publish, and engage with readers, they continue to build upon the long-standing traditions of books, reading, writing, and literary scholarship.

She argued that the real challenge is not deciding which model is superior, but finding ways to harmonize both approaches to strengthen readership, literary development, and creative expression. Although she acknowledged that some writers still prefer printed books, physical meetings, and face-to-face literary engagements, she maintained that there is sufficient room for both systems to coexist and complement one another.

Mrs. Muhammad pointed to the COVID-19 pandemic as a defining moment in the growth of digital literary communities. With physical gatherings suspended, writers, readers, scholars, and literary organisations successfully embraced virtual discussions, workshops, conferences, readings, and book launches. According to her, this period demonstrated that literature could continue to thrive even when physical interaction was impossible.

She further noted that today's increasingly interconnected world has made digital participation indispensable. Literary festivals, book fairs, conferences, and academic gatherings now routinely combine physical and virtual participation, allowing writers and readers from different countries to connect without geographical limitations.

Highlighting the opportunities created by digital platforms, Mrs. Muhammad observed that many talented writers who may never have accessed traditional publishing have built audiences through blogs, online journals, social media, and digital literary platforms. These spaces, she said, have helped discover and promote a new generation of writers by removing barriers associated with conventional publishing.

She concluded that the future of literature lies in integrating both traditional and digital literary communities. While physical engagements provide deeper personal connections, mentorship, and richer interactions, digital platforms offer accessibility, flexibility, wider reach, and greater opportunities for collaboration. Together, she said, they create "a stronger, more inclusive literary community capable of nurturing writers, expanding readership, and promoting literature across generations."

MR. EBIKA ANTHONY

Responding to questions on competition within online literary communities and the importance of building meaningful connections, Mr. Ebika Anthony reflected on the evolution of digital literary spaces, noting that writers once had only a few online platforms through which to share their voices. Today, however, literary, performing, and visual artists have access to numerous digital platforms that enable them to reach audiences across the world.

He observed that while this expansion has created greater opportunities, it has also made competition more pronounced. According to him, many online literary platforms continue to motivate writers and promote "the beautiful growth of craftsmanship." At the same time, he expressed concern that many writers publish their work without proper editing or fail to comply with the guidelines of the platforms they use. This, he noted, places an unnecessary burden on administrators and contributes to unhealthy online literary environments.

Mr. Anthony emphasized that platform administrators work diligently to uphold the standards and structures of their communities but are often overwhelmed by submissions that lack adequate editorial refinement. He therefore encouraged writers to approach online literary spaces with greater professionalism and respect for editorial processes.

Drawing from his years of experience in nurturing writers and sustaining artistic communities, Mr. Anthony identified patience as one of the most important qualities for literary artists. He shared that throughout his journey in arts administration, he has learned to ignore "silly and unhealthy talks and remarks from jealous and retrogressive elements," choosing instead to remain focused on meaningful progress.

Offering practical advice to emerging writers, he stressed the importance of revising one's work before publication. As he often tells young writers, "Write and rewrite, and then rewrite a piece before the big eye of the earth sees it." He concluded by affirming that "perseverance and excellence are my watchwords," encouraging literary artists to prioritize quality, resilience, and continuous improvement over unhealthy competition.

On the Challenges Facing Literary Communities

Responding to a follow-up question from the moderator on the major challenges confronting literary groups and community administrators, **MRS. AISHA UMAR MUHAMMAD** drew from her experience organizing literary programmes, webinars, and managing creative writing platforms.

She identified technical difficulties as one of the most immediate challenges, noting that poor internet connectivity, unstable networks, and the difficulty of coordinating speakers from different locations often disrupt online literary events. Invited panelists may struggle to connect, while participants are sometimes unable to join discussions because of network issues.

Funding, she explained, is another significant concern. Most online literary communities operate on a voluntary basis, with organizers receiving little or no financial support despite the

time, resources, and commitment required to sustain regular programmes.

Mrs. Muhammad also highlighted low audience participation, observing that although many people express interest in literary activities, attendance is frequently affected by competing responsibilities and time constraints.

Speaking from personal experience, she recounted managing an online literary platform that hosts book chats and creative writing workshops, as well as coordinating a Creative Writing Club at her university. When transportation challenges made physical meetings impractical, many activities were moved online. However, some students were still unable to participate because they could not afford internet data. On several occasions, she personally sponsored data subscriptions to enable their participation, illustrating what she described as one of the hidden costs of online literary engagement. While technology has expanded access, she noted, not everyone has equal access to the digital resources needed to benefit from it.

She further raised concerns about cybersecurity, explaining that online identities can be cloned by fraudsters who impersonate literary practitioners to scam unsuspecting individuals. She also advocated for more hybrid conferences, arguing that combining physical and virtual participation would enable greater inclusion, particularly for international participants and those unable to travel.

Finally, Mrs. Muhammad addressed the growing influence of artificial intelligence in literary and academic spaces. While acknowledging its usefulness for research and editing, she cautioned that AI also raises important questions about originality, plagiarism, and academic integrity. She emphasized that literary communities must engage thoughtfully with these ethical concerns as technology continues to evolve.

In summary, she identified inadequate funding, technological limitations, internet accessibility, cybersecurity risks, unequal access to digital resources, and the ethical implications of artificial intelligence as some of the major challenges facing contemporary literary communities.

DR. EZIWHO EMENIKE AZUNWO

Responding to questions on how online literary communities have transformed literary networking and their overall impact on writers, Dr. Eziwho Emenike Azunwo drew on his experience as a literary scholar, playwright, lecturer, and editor to describe digital literary spaces as "a strategic rebalancing" rather than a replacement of traditional literary networks.

Reflecting on his years teaching Playwriting at the University of Port Harcourt and later at Rivers State University, he noted that traditional literary engagement was largely built around academic conferences, theatre festivals, workshops, journal publications, and institutional collaborations. While these platforms promoted scholarly rigour and critical depth, they were often constrained by geography, logistics, and time.

According to Dr. Azunwo, online literary communities have fundamentally changed this landscape by removing institutional and geographical barriers. He recalled organizing a hybrid

playwriting workshop that connected playwrights and critics from Birmingham and Accra with his students in Port Harcourt, demonstrating how digital platforms now enable meaningful international collaboration without requiring participants to travel. This experience, he noted, eventually led to the establishment of a hybrid international workshop series.

Speaking on literary development, he observed that digital platforms have transformed the learning process by enabling immediate feedback and real-time collaboration. Drawing from his own creative practice, he shared how comments from fellow playwrights in Nairobi and Cameroon helped him revise a dramatic scene within hours before testing it with his students the following day. Such experiences, he explained, have enriched both his teaching and his creative work.

Dr. Azunwo also argued that online literary communities have shifted literary growth from institutional gatekeeping to greater visibility based on the quality of one's work. He recounted how an excerpt from one of his plays attracted the attention of an international literary editor, opening publication opportunities and creating mentorship prospects for some of his students. In his view, digital platforms reward consistent, high-quality work while traditional literary institutions continue to provide the critical standards and scholarly discipline necessary for lasting literary development.

From his perspective as Editor-in-Chief of the RSU Journal of Theatre and Film Studies and the *Elegbakna Journal of Theatre and Film Studies*, Dr. Azunwo described the overall impact of online literary communities as "transformative, yet double-edged." He noted that digital technologies have democratized access to literary opportunities, accelerated editorial and peer-review processes, and expanded collaboration beyond national boundaries. However, he cautioned that greater access also demands greater discernment, warning that visibility should never be mistaken for literary excellence.

He further observed that online platforms have made writers more audience-conscious and entrepreneurial by exposing them to immediate public engagement. At the same time, he warned against allowing audience reactions or social media popularity to replace the critical judgment provided by editors, mentors, and peer reviewers.

Concluding his remarks, Dr. Eziwho encouraged writers to embrace the strengths of both traditional and digital literary communities. "Use online communities for reach and iteration," he advised, "but anchor yourself in the rigour of traditional literary and scholarly values." According to him, it is at the intersection of accessibility, innovation, discipline, and critical scholarship that the most enduring literary works are produced.

CONTRIBUTIONS FROM PARTICIPANTS:

PROF. SEGUN ADEKOYA

Responding to a question on how digital literary communities have influenced mentorship, Prof. Segun reflected on the transformation of his mentoring approach over the years, drawing comparisons between traditional face-to-face interactions and today's technology-driven

methods.

Sharing his personal experience, he recalled that his earlier mentoring sessions were conducted physically, with students gathering on weekends to present poems, short stories, essays, and dramatic works for detailed discussion, critique, and revision. According to him, these sessions were highly interactive and provided opportunities for direct engagement between mentor and mentees.

Today, however, the process has become largely digital. Students now submit their manuscripts electronically, allowing him to review, edit, and return them with comments and suggestions online. He observed that technology has made mentoring more efficient by providing access to digital tools that assist with grammar, spelling, formatting, and other aspects of manuscript editing. Unlike the past, when he relied solely on his knowledge, experience, and training, these tools now make the editorial process faster and more convenient. He also encouraged young writers to take advantage of such resources to improve their work before seeking professional feedback.

While acknowledging these benefits, Prof. Segun emphasized that technology, like every innovation, has both advantages and limitations. Echoing an earlier point made by Mrs. Aisha Umar Muhammad, he noted that digital platforms have also introduced challenges such as identity theft, impersonation, misinformation, and cyber fraud, making it necessary for writers to exercise caution in online spaces.

He further identified inadequate infrastructure as a major obstacle to effective digital mentorship. Reliable electricity and stable internet connectivity, he explained, remain essential for virtual meetings, manuscript reviews, and literary discussions, yet persistent power outages and poor network services continue to disrupt these activities.

Despite embracing digital tools, Prof. Segun admitted that he still enjoys working with printed manuscripts. He finds hard copies more comfortable for detailed reading and annotation, as they allow him to read and make handwritten notes anywhere without depending on electronic devices.

He concluded that while digital technology has significantly expanded opportunities for mentorship and literary collaboration, its full potential can only be realized by addressing the practical challenges associated with infrastructure, internet accessibility, and online security.

DAME JOAN ORJI

Adding her voice to the discussion, Dame Joan Orji affirmed many of the points raised by earlier speakers, particularly on mentorship, constructive criticism, and the opportunities created by digital literary communities.

She commended Mr. Jerry Adesewo for his dedication to mentoring writers through manuscript reviews and constructive feedback, while observing that not every writer receives criticism positively. According to her, many writers interpret corrections as personal attacks rather than

opportunities for growth. Reflecting on her own experience, she explained that this realization influenced her decision to charge for editing and proofreading services, noting that people often place greater value on professional feedback when they invest in it.

Dame Orji also agreed that technology has transformed literary mentorship by making it possible for writers, editors, and mentors to collaborate without meeting physically. She acknowledged, however, that these opportunities are still limited by practical challenges such as inconsistent electricity supply and unequal access to reliable internet services. While some people enjoy faster 4G and 5G connectivity, she noted that many Nigerians still depend on slower networks, affecting their ability to participate fully in online literary activities.

Speaking from her experience within the Association of Nigerian Authors (ANA), she encouraged greater adoption of digital platforms for literary engagement. She cited the monthly online meetings coordinated by Prof. Nduka, which connect writers from different parts of Nigeria and the diaspora, as an example of how technology has expanded literary participation despite geographical barriers.

Beyond digital access, Dame Orji emphasized the importance of how criticism is delivered within literary communities. She shared that whenever she notices grammatical or stylistic errors in a writer's online post, she prefers to send corrections privately rather than criticize the individual publicly. In her view, constructive criticism should be offered with kindness, respect, and professionalism so that it encourages growth rather than discouragement.

She concluded by reminding participants that constructive criticism remains indispensable to literary development. Writers, she said, should cultivate the humility to receive feedback while mentors and editors should deliver their observations with empathy and discretion, thereby fostering healthier and more supportive literary communities.

DR. AWELE ILUSANMI, FANA

Contributing to the discussion, Dr. Awele Ilusanmi reflected on the power of collaboration within literary communities, drawing from her experiences in both Nigeria and the diaspora. She recalled that in 2018, over 100 authors were published in a single day in Lagos, describing the achievement as a testament to what literary communities can accomplish when members work together.

Speaking on professional support within creative spaces, Dr. Ilusanmi emphasized the importance of valuing the contributions of editors, proofreaders, and other publishing professionals. She noted that even when writers cannot afford full professional fees, offering an honorarium is a meaningful way to acknowledge their effort and expertise.

Although she enjoys both physical and virtual literary communities, she described online platforms as particularly transformative. Despite currently residing in Texas, she remains actively engaged with her literary community through digital platforms, demonstrating how technology enables writers to stay connected and contribute regardless of geographical location.

She also shared how technology has enhanced her own writing and editing process. While she enjoys the experience of developmental editing with a physical book, she also writes and edits on her mobile phone whenever she is on the move, highlighting the flexibility digital tools provide.

Dr. Ilusanmi challenged participants to think beyond simply belonging to online communities and instead consider whether they are fully utilizing their collective potential. Using Authors Hub as an example, she observed that with more than 800 members, even a modest financial contribution from each author toward a colleague's book launch could provide substantial support. She reminded participants that "we are our own first audience," encouraging members to intentionally purchase, promote, recommend, and review one another's books.

Drawing another example from the Litaco community, she explained that when a member publishes a book, fellow authors often read the work, write reviews, and even contribute financially to support the launch. Although members occasionally meet physically, much of this collaboration takes place online, illustrating how digital communities can foster meaningful professional support.

She concluded by encouraging literary communities to cultivate a culture of intentional collaboration, where authors actively invest in one another's growth through promotion, mentorship, reviews, and practical support, both online and offline.

SUMAILAISAH UMAISHA

Responding to Dr. Awele Ilusanmi's contribution on mutual support within literary communities, Mallam Umaisha acknowledged the value of writers intentionally supporting one another but emphasized the importance of transparency and trust in sustaining such initiatives.

He observed that many writers join literary communities primarily to benefit from them rather than contribute to their growth. For this reason, he advised that anyone establishing a literary platform should be prepared to fund it personally in its early stages or seek external sponsorship and grants where necessary.

According to him, requesting financial contributions from members without a transparent system may create suspicion, with some participants assuming that the platform exists merely to collect money. Such perceptions, he noted, can undermine trust and discourage active participation.

Nevertheless, Mallam Umaisha affirmed that well-organized systems of mutual support can significantly strengthen literary communities. He encouraged initiatives that promote accountability and transparency, noting that collaborative efforts through book promotion, reviews, mentorship, and financial support can help more writers succeed while fostering a stronger and more united literary community.

PAUL LIAM

Contributing to the discussion, Paul Liam described the conversation as both timely and necessary, emphasizing the transformative role of virtual literary communities in strengthening literature and supporting writers across geographical boundaries.

Speaking from his experience as an emerging writer, he noted that one of the greatest advantages of digital literary spaces is the opportunity to connect with established writers, scholars, and literary practitioners from different parts of the world. He observed that virtual platforms have made it possible for young writers to interact with literary icons and respected professionals, opportunities that would have been difficult to access through traditional means. According to him, these interactions allow the older generation to pass on the values, traditions, and best practices of the literary profession to younger writers.

Paul also acknowledged the contributions of Dr. Awele Ilusanmi, commending her commitment to supporting and mentoring emerging writers. He cited her generosity as an example of the empathy and collaboration that literary communities should continue to foster.

Expanding on the idea of community support, he stressed that meaningful assistance extends beyond financial contributions. In his view, supporting fellow writers also involves reading their work, providing constructive criticism, offering editorial guidance, writing reviews, encouraging them to keep writing, and mentoring those who are still developing their craft.

He further observed that many emerging writers share poems, stories, and essays online in the hope of receiving thoughtful feedback, only to be met with silence. Such lack of engagement, he noted, can discourage creativity and diminish writers' confidence. For this reason, he described constructive engagement as one of the greatest gifts members of a literary community can offer one another.

Paul concluded by calling for stronger mentorship structures within literary communities. He encouraged experienced writers to intentionally guide younger authors through constructive critique, editorial support, networking opportunities, encouragement, and practical assistance wherever possible, noting that such deliberate collaboration would contribute to a stronger and more supportive literary ecosystem.

DR. AHMED WADA IKAKA

Responding to the moderator's remarks on the accessibility of virtual literary communities, Dr. Ahmed Wada Ikaka highlighted the flexibility of online platforms, noting that they make it possible for individuals with demanding professional and personal responsibilities to remain actively involved in literary engagements.

Before addressing the moderator's question, he returned to the earlier discussion on financial support within literary communities. Describing writers' groups as associations built on shared interests, he argued that members should intentionally support one another through structured welfare initiatives and collective contributions. Commending Dr. Awele Ilusanmi's proposal, he observed that even modest donations of ₦1,000 or ₦2,000 from members could provide meaningful support for authors, particularly at a time when publishing costs continue to rise and

many publishers are reluctant to invest in emerging writers. He likened such initiatives to cooperative societies, where members contribute towards one another's welfare during significant life events, suggesting that literary communities could adopt similar models to strengthen authors and promote literary development.

Reflecting on his own literary journey, Dr. Ikaka remarked, "What is truly within you will always remain with you." He recalled participating in weekly creative writing workshops during his university days at Bayero University, Kano, emphasizing that literature had long been an integral part of his life despite the many responsibilities he later assumed.

He further shared that, in addition to being a farmer and administrator, he had recently contested for a seat in the House of Representatives. If elected, he expressed his desire to champion legislation that would advance the interests of writers and strengthen literary development, stressing that many of the changes the literary community seeks require legislative support. He therefore encouraged writers not to shy away from public service and political participation.

Speaking on resilience, Dr. Ikaka remarked that "even a zigzag road can still take you to your destination," encouraging writers to embrace life's challenges as opportunities for growth rather than obstacles to success. Concluding his remarks, he described the convenience of online literary communities as one of their greatest strengths. Despite his busy schedule, he noted that he is able to participate in literary discussions from virtually anywhere, including while working on his yam and rice farms, simply by connecting through his mobile phone whenever network coverage is available. According to him, this flexibility enables him to remain productive in both his professional and literary pursuits, demonstrating "the power and convenience of online literary communities."

CLOSING REMARKS

PROF. SEGUN ADEKOYA

In his concluding remarks, Prof. Segun drew participants' attention to plagiarism, describing it as one of the most pressing issues confronting writers in the age of online publishing and artificial intelligence.

He observed that AI tools such as ChatGPT have become increasingly integrated into the writing process, raising important questions about originality, authorship, and ethical writing practices. While acknowledging that many regard AI as simply another writing aid, comparable to dictionaries, search engines, or grammar-checking software, he challenged participants to consider a more fundamental question: "Where do we draw the line?" At what point, he asked, does the use of artificial intelligence cease to be assistance and become plagiarism?

Prof. Segun further broadened the discussion by questioning conventional understandings of copyright and intellectual ownership. "Who owns language?" he asked, inviting participants to reflect on whether anyone can truly claim ownership of words, expressions, metaphors, or cultural ideas that have evolved collectively over generations. He suggested that the rapid advancement of technology may require society to rethink traditional assumptions about

originality, creativity, and intellectual property.

Describing the present moment as "a brave new world," he noted that many of the controversies surrounding AI-assisted writing are only "the tip of the iceberg," arguing that the literary community is still adapting to profound technological changes that demand deeper reflection rather than quick judgments.

He concluded by recommending that a future Authors Hub session be devoted entirely to plagiarism in the age of artificial intelligence, where participants could critically examine its ethical, legal, philosophical, and creative implications. Such conversations, he noted, are essential if writers are to navigate the evolving relationship between technology and literary creativity with wisdom and responsibility.

SUMAILAISAH UMAISHA

Responding to Prof. Segun's remarks on plagiarism and artificial intelligence, Sumalia Umaisha emphasized the importance of using AI responsibly as a support tool rather than allowing it to replace the creative process.

He explained that there is nothing inherently wrong with using AI applications such as ChatGPT to correct typographical errors, improve grammar, or refine the language of a manuscript. In his view, these are legitimate uses of technology that help writers polish their work without compromising originality.

However, he cautioned against the growing temptation to rely on AI to generate ideas, organize arguments, or produce complete literary works. According to him, once artificial intelligence assumes the role of the creator, the work begins to lose its artistic essence because "the purpose of art is to express the individuality of the creator."

Umaisha stressed that every writer possesses a distinctive voice, perspective, and style, qualities that give literature its authenticity and enduring value. While AI can assist in refining expression, it should never replace the imagination, originality, and personal voice that define creative writing. He therefore encouraged writers to regard artificial intelligence as an assistant to creativity rather than a substitute for it, ensuring that technology enhances rather than diminishes the writer's unique artistic identity.

DR. EZEKIEL FAJENYO

In his closing contribution, Dr. Ezekiel Fajenyo commended the quality of the discussion, describing the presentations as thoughtful, well-researched, and highly insightful. He expressed admiration for the preparedness of the speakers and noted that the session had been both motivating and intellectually enriching for experienced and emerging writers alike.

Reflecting on the day's conversations, Dr. Fajenyo expressed confidence in the direction of the literary community, emphasizing the need for greater collaboration and integration among writers. Echoing the views of earlier contributors, including Dr. Ahmed Wada Ikaka and Dr.

Awele Ilusanmi, he encouraged writers to continue supporting one another through mentorship, collaboration, and regular engagement, whether in physical or virtual spaces.

He observed that such interactions create opportunities for the exchange of ideas, mutual encouragement, and continuous learning while providing younger writers with access to guidance and mentorship that was not always readily available in the past. According to him, these communities play a vital role in shaping the next generation of literary artists.

Returning to the issue of plagiarism and artificial intelligence, Dr. Fajenyo endorsed the earlier recommendation that a future session be dedicated entirely to the subject. He stressed the importance of helping writers understand the ethical, legal, and creative implications of plagiarism, particularly in an era of rapidly advancing AI technologies. In his view, strengthening ethical awareness within the literary community is essential to preserving the integrity of literature and equipping writers to use emerging technologies responsibly.

Dr. Fajenyo concluded by expressing heartfelt appreciation to all participants for their valuable contributions. He encouraged writers to remain committed to continuous learning, personal growth, professional excellence, and mutual support, affirming that through collective effort the literary community can continue to grow stronger and make lasting contributions to the advancement of literature.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Online literary communities have expanded access to mentorship, networking, and global opportunities for writers.
- Digital platforms should complement, not replace, reading, research, and consistent writing.
- Growth in literature is built on authenticity, discipline, patience, and continuous learning.- Constructive criticism and mentorship remain essential for developing writers.
- Literary communities thrive when members actively support one another through promotion, reviews, and collaboration.
- While technology creates new opportunities, challenges such as poor connectivity, funding, and AI ethics require ongoing attention.
- AI should enhance creativity, not replace the writer's unique voice.
- The future of literature lies in effectively integrating traditional and digital literary communities.

Celina Chinwemmeri Ikehukwu, the Authors' Hub rapporteur, is a student and an award-winning writer

THE ART OF ACTING: CRAFT, CALLING, AND CONSECRATION

A key note lecture delivered on the occasion of X-theatre (drama) ministers' retreat of The Rest Place, Church of God Mission International (CGMi)

Lecture prepared and delivered

by:

Eziwho Emenike Azunwo, PhD

Academic Rabbi

Department of Theatre and Film Studies, Faculty of Humanities

¹Rivers State University, Nkpolu- Oroworukwo, P.M.B. 5080

Port Harcourt, Rivers State

Nigeria

Email: emenike.eziwho@ust.edu.ng

Date: 25th July. 2026

Venue: The Rest Place, CGMi, KDC Hall, 202a Aba Road, Waterlines, Port Harcourt.

Time: 9:00am – 2:00pm

Introduction: Acting as an Art and an Altar

Good day, brethren, ministers, and fellow artists. When we hear the phrase “The Art of Acting,” our minds immediately travel to technique. We think of voice projection that fills a hall without a microphone. We think of character analysis, motivation, objectives, and obstacles. We think of stage presence, blocking, timing, and emotional truth. In the secular academy, theatre is treated as a discipline to be mastered through years of study and practice. But in the context of Christian ministry, acting must rise beyond technique. It must become consecrated craft. The stage becomes an altar. The actor becomes a priest. The performance becomes an offering. We are not here to entertain for vanity. We are here to steward gifts. We are here to tell stories that reflect truth, expose the human condition, and ultimately point men to divine grace. If we miss this, we reduce sacred work to mere show business. If we embrace it, we discover that acting is both art and altar.

Biblical Foundation for Stewardship

The Bible is clear about gifts. 1 Peter 4:10 says, “As each has received a gift, use it to serve one another, as good stewards of God’s varied grace.” Notice two words: gift and stewardship. Your talent is the gift. God sovereignly places it in you. Your technique is the stewardship. That is your responsibility. God gives the raw material — the voice, the body, the imagination, the sensitivity. But He expects us to refine it. In the parable of the talents, the master did not praise the servant who buried his talent. He praised the ones who worked it, multiplied it, and returned it with increase. Acting talent buried under laziness, pride, or “waiting for anointing” is still burial. We must rehearse. We must study. We must train. Because when we stand before an audience, we are not just representing ourselves. We are representing the God who gave us the gift. Stewardship demands excellence, preparation, and accountability.

The Danger of Extremes: Anointing vs Artistry

In Christian circles we often swing to extremes. One extreme says, “We don’t need training. Just the Holy Ghost.” The other says, “We don’t need the Spirit. Just good acting.” Both are dangerous. Theatre ministry is not “spirit-coco” alone. You cannot walk on stage with no blocking, no voice work, no character study, and expect the Spirit to do what discipline should have done. That is presumption. But you can also have perfect diction, perfect movement, and a dead spirit. That is performance without power. Anointing without skill leads to sloppy ministry that embarrasses the Gospel. Skill without the Spirit leads to hollow entertainment that moves emotions but not hearts. The truth is both hands washing each other. The Spirit empowers the craft. The craft gives the Spirit a worthy vessel. Jesus was full of the Spirit and full of wisdom. Paul was anointed and was also a trained rhetorician. We must pursue both.

Pillar 1: Truthfulness in Portrayal

The foundation of modern acting theory, from Konstantin Stanislavski to Sanford Meisner, is one idea: living truthfully under imaginary circumstances. The audience must believe you before they will believe your message. In ministry drama, this is even more critical. If we portray sin in a cartoonish way, people will not see themselves. If we portray repentance with exaggerated crying and falling, people will disengage. If we portray redemption as a magic trick, people will leave unchanged. Truthfulness means doing the research. What does addiction really look like? What does grief really sound like? What does conviction really feel like? We must live the character from the inside out. Not “act” the pastor, but become a man wrestling with calling. Not “act” the prostitute, but become a woman with wounds and choices. When truth is on stage, the Holy Spirit has something to anoint. When there is only performance, the Spirit has nothing to bless.

Pillar 2: Voice, Body, and Presence

God gave you a body as a physical stage and a voice as a trumpet. Isaiah 58:1 — “Lift up your voice like a trumpet.” In theatre, there is no rewind button. If the last row cannot hear you, your sermon is lost. Vocal clarity is therefore a spiritual responsibility. We must train breath support, articulation, resonance, and projection. The body is equally important. Every step, every gesture, every facial expression is communicating. Physical economy means no wasted movement. Unnecessary pacing, fidgeting, or “pussy-footing” distracts from the message. Your presence must command attention without demanding it. This is not pride. This is stewardship. David danced with all his might before the Lord. That was a physical offering. When we bring a disciplined body and a trained voice to God, our performance itself becomes worship. The medium becomes sacred.

Pillar 3: Empathy and Character Study

Acting requires the terrifying and beautiful act of stepping into someone else’s shoes. Sometimes those shoes belong to heroes of faith. Sometimes they belong to villains, backsliders, hypocrites, and broken people. To play them truthfully, you cannot judge them from the outside. You must seek to understand their motives, their wounds, their logic. Why did Judas betray? Why did Peter deny? Why does the young man choose fraud? This builds empathy. And empathy is not compromise. It is Christlikeness. Jesus wept with those who wept. He ate with

sinner not to endorse sin, but to understand and redeem. As actors and ministers, empathy allows us to portray humanity without condemnation, so that the audience sees themselves and sees a way out. Without empathy, our drama becomes moral lectures. With empathy, our drama becomes ministry.

Major Theories of Acting We Must Know

We cannot be ignorant of the tools of our trade. **Stanislavski's System** teaches us objectives, actions, and the "magic if." It asks, "What would I do if I were in this situation?" **Meisner Technique** teaches us to live truthfully in the moment and to react honestly to our scene partner. **Brechtian Epic Theatre** teaches us to create distance so the audience can think critically and not just feel. **Grotowski's Poor Theatre** strips away spectacle and says the actor-audience relationship is the core. **Uta Hagen** teaches substitution and truth. We do not adopt these theories wholesale. We baptize them. We filter them through Scripture. But to ignore them is to go to war unarmed. A minister who knows theology but not hermeneutics will misquote the Bible. In the same way, a drama minister who knows the anointing but not craft will misrepresent the truth.

Why Theory Matters in Ministry

Some people say, "Theory is for the university. We are for the church." That is a false divide. Theory is simply tested wisdom about how human beings behave, communicate, and change. When we understand objectives, we can make our characters purposeful instead of random. When we understand beats, we can structure a scene so it builds to a Gospel point. When we understand subtext, we can say one thing and mean another, just like Jesus in parables. Theory gives us precision. And precision honors God. God is a God of order, not confusion. When we are vague on stage, the message is vague in the heart. When we are specific, the Spirit can be specific in conviction. Ignorance of craft limits the reach of anointing. But knowledge submitted to the Spirit multiplies impact.

Drama as a Ministerial Tool

Why drama? Why not just preach? Because stories bypass human defenses. The human heart is guarded against direct confrontation. But a story slips past the gate. In 2 Samuel 12, Nathan did not begin with, "David, you are an adulterer and murderer." He told a story about a rich man and a poor man's ewe lamb. David's heart was moved to judgment before he realized the story was about him. That is the power of drama. Drama mirrors life. It holds up a mirror and says, "This is you." It pierces the heart without bruising the ego. It leads to self-realization. And self-realization is the doorway to repentance. Drama also heals. When people see their pain named on stage, they feel less alone. When they see a way forward dramatized, they receive hope. This is why Jesus taught in parables. He was the greatest drama minister.

Relevance in the Contemporary Body of Christ

The Church today is in competition for attention. Our members watch Netflix, TikTok, Nollywood, and YouTube for 4 hours a day. Then they come to church for 1 hour. If our drama is 20 minutes of shouting, dancing without purpose, and songs in the wrong key, we are losing them. But people still hunger for meaning. They hunger for stories that make sense of suffering,

injustice, and redemption. Christian drama can meet that hunger — but only if it is excellent. Mediocre drama pushes people away from the Church. It confirms the stereotype that “Christian things are not professional.” Excellent drama draws people to Christ because it respects them. In an age of distraction, excellence is evangelism. In an age of noise, truth told well is prophetic.

Relevance to Society at Large

Theatre has always been the conscience of society. From the Greek tragedies to Wole Soyinka, theatre holds a mirror to the nation. It asks hard questions. It exposes corruption. It laments injustice. It celebrates virtue. When the Church abandons this space, the world fills it with its own narratives — often destructive ones. If we are not telling stories about marriage, money, leadership, and integrity, Nollywood will. If we are not dramatizing the cost of fraud, the pain of broken homes, or the beauty of forgiveness, secular media will, and they will do it without hope. We must reclaim storytelling as a prophetic act. Not to copy the world, but to redeem the form. To show that the Gospel speaks to every area of life, not just Sunday.

Avenue 1: Preaching Without Preachiness

A sound Christian drama should not hammer the audience over the head with doctrine. People are tired of being shouted at. What they need is to see truth. Good drama illustrates the human experience so clearly that the truth becomes self-evident. The audience concludes what the sermon would have told them, but they conclude it themselves. That is more powerful. Doctrine is important, but people need to see doctrine embodied. Show me a man choosing forgiveness instead of telling me about forgiveness. Show me a woman choosing purity under pressure instead of preaching purity. When truth is enfleshed, it is more convincing than when it is only announced.

Avenue 2: Service to Humanity – Mirroring Reality

Theatre serves society by holding a mirror to its wounds. When a widow sees her grief portrayed with dignity, she feels seen. When a teenager sees the trap of internet fraud dramatized, he is warned. When a couple sees communication breakdown acted out, they are convicted. This is service. Jesus spent most of His ministry meeting people at the point of their need. Drama allows us to do the same at scale. We can take the pain of a community and put it on stage, not to shame, but to heal. We can show injustice, not to incite violence, but to call for repentance. When an audience sees their reality reflected with compassion and with a path to redemption, the door to the heart opens.

Avenue 3: Service to God – Excellence as Worship

In the Old Testament, God rejected blemished sacrifices. He said, “Bring your best.” That principle has not changed. Offering God half-hearted, unprepared, last-minute drama is a blemished offering. Excellence is not pride. Excellence is worship. When we memorize our lines, it is worship. When we block a scene 10 times, it is worship. When we design a set with care, it is worship. When we arrive early for rehearsal, it is worship. Colossians 3:23 — “Whatever you do, do it unto the Lord.” Our performance itself can be a liturgy. When technique and Spirit meet, the audience does not just applaud. They encounter God.

Expectations of the Church from Drama Ministers

The Church has the right to expect three things from us. **First, Integrity.** Live what you perform. You cannot preach holiness on stage and live in compromise off stage. The anointing and the lifestyle must match. **Second, Excellence.** Come prepared. Know your lines. Respect rehearsal times. Treat props and costumes with care. Stop treating ministry as casual. **Third, Discernment.** Choose stories that edify, not just entertain. Not every trending topic deserves a skit. Ask: Does this glorify God? Does this build the Church? Does this reflect biblical truth? We are not comedians for hire. We are custodians of sacred narrative. The pulpit is holy. So is the stage.

Expectations of Society from Christian Theatre

Society is also watching us. And they expect three things. **Relevance.** Speak to their real issues: economy, family, mental health, leadership. **Research.** Do your homework. If you are doing a play about cultism, talk to people. Don't just guess. **Respect.** Respect the audience's intelligence. Stop with the funny costumes that make us a joke, the off-key singing, and the drama that ends with "and then Jesus came." We can be funny without being foolish. We can be spiritual without being shallow. If we raise the standard, the schools, NGOs, and media houses will invite us. If we don't, we will remain in the corner, singing to ourselves.

The Cost of Mediocrity

Let us tell ourselves the truth. A lot of people see Christian theatre as a joke because we have treated it as a joke. We rehearse once. We use any cloth. We scream to cover lack of technique. We laugh at our own mistakes on stage. Then we wonder why nobody takes us seriously. Colleagues, we play in the theatre. But we must never play with the theatre. The theatre is serious. It shapes culture. It shapes souls. Sloppy craft does not just waste time. It damages the credibility of the Gospel. It tells the world that God is not worth our best. We must repent of mediocrity and embrace discipline as a spiritual act.

Discipleship Through Drama

The process of acting is itself discipleship. Memorization forces the Word into your spirit. Rehearsal builds diligence and patience. Character study builds compassion for people different from you. Teamwork kills pride and selfishness. Receiving correction builds humility. Fasting before a major production builds dependence on God. The stage is a school. It is not just where we perform. It is where we are formed. Many actors have come to Christ through drama ministry because the discipline exposed their heart. Many ministers have grown in wisdom because playing different characters taught them to see life from other angles. God uses the craft to shape the crafter.

Conclusion and Call to Craft

Colleagues, hear me clearly. There is a distinction we must never forget. **Secular acting asks:** How can I get the audience to look at me? **Ministerial acting asks:** How can I use myself so the audience sees the Truth? One seeks applause. The other seeks transformation. One seeks fame. The other seeks faithfulness. Do not settle for mediocre drama. Do not settle for spiritual

laziness. Rehearse with precision. Study your characters deeply. Master voice, body, and text. Read the theories. Practice the craft. And do it all with a heart surrendered to God and devoted to serving your audience.

Final Charge: Priesthood on the Platform

When technique meets the truth of the Gospel, lives are transformed. I have seen hardened men weep. I have seen addicts get delivered. I have seen backsliders return, all because a story was told well and told with the Spirit. The stage is not just a platform. It is a pulpit. It is not just performance. It is priesthood. You are not just an actor. You are a steward, a witness, a voice. May God find us faithful in this art and on this altar. May our lives and our craft point every eye away from us and to Jesus. For to Him belongs all glory, now and forever. Amen.

Eziwho Emenike Azunwo, PhD

Academic Rabbi is an Associate Professor of Literary Criticism and Playwriting in the Department of Theatre and Film Studies, Rivers State University. He has authored over 147 plays.



AUTHORS' HUB PRESENTS

The 14th Edition Of Its Monthly Panel Discussion
Via Google Meet.

TOPIC:

**Literary Networking:
The Benefits And Challenges Of Online Literary Communities**



Dr. Eziwho E. Azunwo



Mrs. Zuwaiba Hallitu-Moderator



Mr. Jerry Adesewo



Aisha U. Muhammad



Mr. Ebika Anthony



Keriah O. Kargbo

Link: <https://meet.google.com/zyn-ximv-ruf>

DATE: 27TH JUNE, 2026

TIME: 4:30PM - 6:00PM